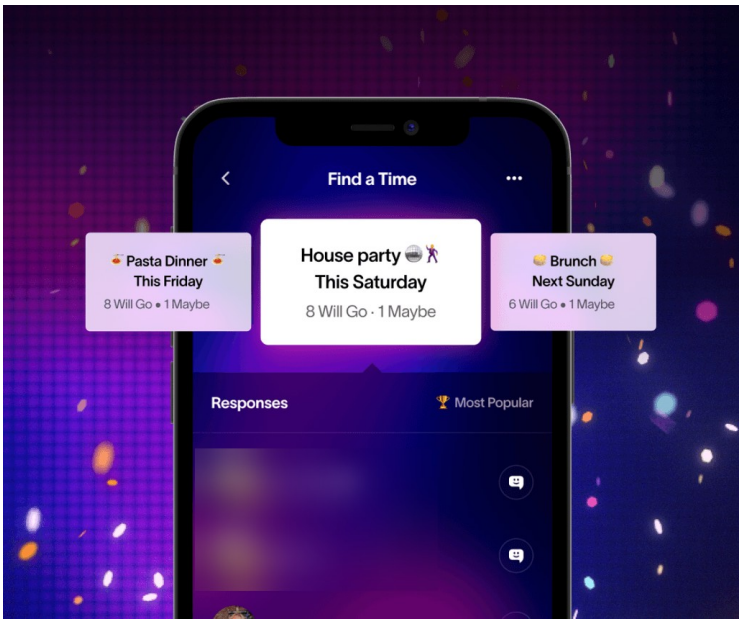


partiful

Usability Study Report

ISE 215, Spring 2025

Gabrielle Orzech, Jackson Burke, Liz Almonte, Nicholas Mitchell, Vipashyana Patel

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Executive Summary

Purpose of Report

This report presents a usability evaluation of the event organizing platform Partiful, a mobile event planning application. Our firm was hired to conduct structured usability testing in order to identify usability issues and provide actionable recommendations to improve the overall user experience.

Study Purpose

The primary goal of this study was to assess whether Partiful's user experience aligns with its brand and business objectives, including:

- Simplifying hosting and guest management
- Maintaining a fun, social tone
- Enabling connection with partygoers, without relying on external tools or messaging platforms

Report Structure

This report is divided into two core sections:

I. Context & Methodology

- Overview of the product and its intended use cases
- User profiles representing the expected Partiful user base
- A preliminary heuristic evaluation based on established usability principles
- Study setup, including:
    - Participant selection & recruitment
    - Study structure and task design
    - Moderator script excerpts and setup procedures

This section captures how we designed the study to evaluate both host and guest perspectives, revealing potential friction points in the user journey through realistic task scenarios.

II. Observations & Findings

- Task-by-task findings, presented by scenario (RSVP, event editing, messaging, etc.)
- Triangulation of:
    - Performance measures
    - Behavioral observations
    - Subjective feedback
- Cross-task global usability themes
- A cumulative heuristic violation scorecard
- A high-level usability scorecard (graded across learnability, feedback, navigation, and more)
- Final design recommendations, prioritized by severity and user impact

Our Goal

To provide Partiful with evidence-based insights and clear design direction that support improved:

- Trust and transparency around public vs. private interactions
- Discoverability of key features for both new and experienced users
- Clarity in system feedback, messaging, and guest-host communication flows

Product Overview



Partiful is a mobile-first event planning platform designed to simplify the process of hosting, RSVPing, and social engagement. Rather than relying on group chats, calendar invites, and scattered DMS, Partiful aims to bring all party logistics and communication to one space.The platform is built around the belief that parties are not just logistical events, but relationship building moments and that tools for gathering should reflect that!

RSVPs are tied to phone numbers, enabling text-based notifications and reminders, while guest visibility, social sharing, and comment threads make parties feel more personal and engaging. After the event, attendees can reconnect with each other through the app, without needing to swap contact info in advance.

While the platform offers a broader range of features, including co-hosting, questionnaires, and payment integration, this usability study focused specifically on how users experience the core guest and host flows, including:

- RSVP and information sharing
- Event creation and editing
- Guest updates and messaging
- Public vs. private visibility expectations

This framing allows us to assess whether Partiful delivers on its core brand promise of helping people make friends and memories, while keeping social planning simple, expressive, and trustworthy.

User Types

Partiful primarily caters to a younger, socially active demographic, but it's intended use and flexible format have made it a go-to-tool for a range of event types - from intimate birthday gatherings to larger-scale community events like thrift markets or DJ sets. Below is a breakdown of the core user types observed or anticipated through our analysis:

User Type	Description	Top Goals
Social Young Adults	Predominantly Gen Z and Millennials using Partiful for birthdays, dinner parties, or casual hangouts.	- Create or RSVP to events quickly- Hype up parties with comments- Stay connected post-event
Event Hosts (Public/Semi-Public)	Users who throw larger events like pop-ups, DJ sets, or thrift markets using Partiful as a landing page.	- Share links broadly via social- Present a fun brand/event vibe- Update guests at scale
Mobile-Native Guests	Attendees who join via shared links, often friends-of-friends with no prior experience on Partiful.	- RSVP with ease- Understand what info is shared- Feel confident that their input was saved
Friend-of-a-Friend Connectors	Users who are invited through extended social circles and use Partiful to reconnect with others.	- Message someone they met at a party- Check the guest list- Build casual new connections
First-Time Hosts	Users who are planning a one-time event and are unfamiliar with event platforms.	- Set up an event quickly- Communicate updates without managing multiple apps

Product Tasks & Company Goals

Partiful's broader product ecosystem includes features like co-hosting, guest approvals, and payment collection. However, this usability study focused on core social planning workflows that support the company's mission:

"To help people make friends (and memories)."

- *Partiful*

The tasks selected for evaluation were chosen based on their alignment with Partiful's core brand goals and the most common host/guest use cases. Below is a breakdown of the platforms primary tasks and the company goals those tasks are meant to fulfill:

Product Task	Company Goal
Create a party page and invite guests	Make it easy for hosts to set the vibe and logistics in one place, no more juggling 6+ apps
RSVP to an event and provide personal info (e.g., dietary)	Ensure guests can join quickly and safely, while feeling informed and in control
Edit key details (time, location, description)	Support last-minute flexibility with minimal friction
Notify guests of changes or updates	Keep everyone aligned with clear, timely communication without needing separate messaging apps
Reconnect with guests after the event	Encourage casual connections and build community through social follow-up tools
Leave a personal comment or interact on the event page	Promote casual, community driven engagement during and after RSVP

Methodology of Evaluation Process

Our team started by getting familiar with the interface and navigation of the Partiful application – noting down features that grabbed our attention and other aspects of the beginner's experience with the app. To better understand how users naturally engage with the app, we used the app to organize our future meetings. We made sure to utilize

the additional features provided and noted down our experiences and difficulties through the process of being a host and attendee. This was accompanied by a heuristic evaluation of the app to dive deeper into what and how key usability principles were violated.

USER PROFILES & EXPERTISE:

The results from our thorough preliminary research informed us on how the user base would engage with the app. This helped us develop user personas that represent the core audience behaviors and use cases of the app, but also outlined the type of users we were targeting in the study.

Partiful as a service is intended to be a simple, intuitive invitation app that can be quickly learned and used. This core value of simplicity encouraged us to test participants of varying skill levels with the same tasks to see if it is as easily usable across experience levels. We still recorded the experience of each participant in order to check whether this hypothesis was correct, which it ended up being.

To evaluate the holistic usability of the app across skill levels, we developed tasks for the most common scenarios in both roles:

- Receiving and accepting an invite
- Creating an event with specifications and sending it out to guests
- The editing and cancellation of an event
- Connecting with a partygoer from a previous event

What We Measured

We collected three types of measurements to capture the full breadth of the experience with the app, so as to effectively inform our decisions. Our measurements were based on performance, behavioral, and subjective aspects of the experience.

1. **Performance Measures:**

Performance measures are typically quantitative in nature, and we chose these forms of measurement for this study:

- **Time on task:** How long it took a participant to complete the given task.
- **Task completion:** A yes or no record of whether or not the participant saw the task through to completion.
- **Error rate:** How many times the participant selected the incorrect path or option in achieving the provided task.

2. **Behavioral Measures:**

Behavioral measures traditionally look at the participants' natural responses to the given task. Its qualitative nature lets us use their mannerisms and other expressions to understand their thoughts and feelings about the novel experience. We record following measurements to gain this insight:

- **Negative non-verbal mannerisms:** Body language that indicates frustration, dissatisfaction, uneasiness, or other negative emotions produced from the task.
- **Reaching out for assistance:** Requests for help or confirmation on an action that should have been achievable without assistance.
- **Excessive references to instructions:** For simple tasks, the participant should not require frequent refreshes of the task provided. Frequent checks on their progress presents uncertainty in their actions.

3. **Subjective Measures:**

Subjective measures usually come after the participant is finished with their task. This lets us dive more into what they did or did not perceive during the task, motivations behind certain actions and behaviors, and lets them verbalize their opinions and feelings about the task. These come in the form of:

- **Probing questions:** These are the basis for most subjective measures. They let us investigate certain behaviors exhibited during the task, along with testing whether or not the participant was aware of key actions, purpose, or results that

were or were not achieved. The flexibility of these prove to be an invaluable asset in usability testing.

- **Satisfaction:** Lets us understand how content a participant was with the task.
- **Ease of use:** Rates the difficulty of the overall task or manageability of the product.

What We Found

This section of the study discusses the findings from the usability study on the app Partiful. We will look at the results from each task, as they represent a core use case of the app. Then, a discussion of the collective trends across the app.

Task 1: RSVP through text invite

- All 5 participants entered the dietary restrictions intended for the questionnaire into the RSVP comment field.
    - The behavioral consistency across participants demonstrates a systemic usability breakdown, not isolated error.
- 3 of 5 participants assumed that the RSVP box would be private.

    - This comment gets sent to the event page, which is public to all guests. This poses a privacy concern.
    - Creates an uncertainty to what is being shared with others.

Task 2: Creating & editing events

- 4 of 5 participants unaware that edits do not notify guests.
    - Poorly communicating the condition of the system, and to what information is and isn't shared.
- "Text Blast" feature misunderstood or unseen
    - UI didn't visualize the feature in a significant way/occluded it within visually assimilated navigation bar.
    - Term usage is not consistent with other notification features across other products.
- Expectations of the event edit button's location not met.
    - Required, unnecessary embedded navigation.
    - Features not available outside the edit page.
- 2 of 5 placed allergy-related announcement in Event Description rather than RSVP or Food section.
    - Prevents guests from otherwise being aware of a crucial aspect of the event.
    - Option for alternate settings not made aware to participants.
    - Labelling doesn't correctly communicate the purpose of allergy-related settings.

Task 3: Managing location changes & cancellations

- Participants believed guests were automatically informed of event modification. Instead they were required to manually announce the change via "Text Blast".
    - A crucial communication of the condition of the event is not made by the app. Requires manual send out.
    - Furthers trust gap for what is thought to be communicated vs what is.

- 5 of 5 participants uncertain that cancellation notified guests.
    - The culmination of the lack of trust between the app and user.
    - A lack of communication from the app leaves the result of the cancellation ambiguous as to if the notification was received by guests.
    - For such a crucial action, as a guest arriving at a cancelled event is a disastrous situation. There should be no uncertainty as to the condition of the event to either party.

Task 4: Messaging & Guest Communication

- Participants unaware of messaging features at all.
    - Half of the mission statement for the app's objectives was to foster new friendships from the app.
        - This is an astounding result for how crucial of a feature this is to Partiful.
- 1 participant unsure that messages were sent or delivered
    - Lack of trust in system status returns.

Global Findings

Our team identified usability challenges that indicate broader issues with system design, labeling, and user feedback. These global findings represent cross-cutting patterns that go beyond isolated task failures and reflect system-wide breakdowns in visibility, discoverability, and user trust.The following were common themes that may be detrimental to the user experience and overall platform reliability:

- Lack of Clear System Feedback Undermines Trust
- Feature Names and Labels Do Not Match User Expectations
- Unclear Boundaries Between Public and Private Information
- Discoverability of Critical Inputs Is Weak

The usability grades in the scorecard represent our evaluation of key aspects of the Partiful app based on global user testing and feedback. These grades offer a clear snapshot of the app's current performance from a usability perspective.

Usability Question	Grade	Explanation
🧭 *Is the platform easy to learn and use on the first try?*	**B-**	While visually playful, unclear form structure and RSVP flow challenged first-time users.
🔎 *Are core features discoverable and accessible?*	**D+**	Participants struggled to locate key features like "Text Blast" and guest messaging due to poor labeling and navigation cues.
💬 *Does the system provide helpful feedback and confirmations?*	**D**	No clear confirmation for messages or updates left users uncertain and repeatedly second-guessing their actions.
🧠 *Does the interface clearly distinguish public vs. private actions?*	**C-**	Multiple users misunderstood who could see comments or profile info, leading to trust and privacy concerns.
⭐ ***Overall Usability Grade***	**C-**	**Despite a fun, social tone, major gaps in system visibility, trust, and discoverability reduce the platform's effectiveness.**

Our Recommendations

Our team has conducted a thorough analysis of the Partiful app. In this report, we present a set of targeted recommendations aimed at improving the app's functionality, user engagement, and overall user experience. These suggestions are grounded in user feedback, industry trends, and usability principles, and are designed to help Partiful continue growing its community while staying true to its vibrant and social brand identity.

Task 1	
Finding	**Recommendation**
Comment Box Misused for Dietary Information	• When added by host, move dietary input field above the RSVP comment field Add a placeholder to the comment box like "Write a

	greeting for the event feed (public)" ● Trigger a warning if allergy-related terms are detected in the comment field
RSVP Comments Assumed to Be Private	● Add label: "This comment is visible to all guests" ● Show a comment preview before submission ● Offer a separate host-only message field

Task 2	
Finding	**Recommendation**
Users Did Not Realize Guests Wouldn't Be Notified After Edits	● Prompt users after time/location changes: "Would you like to notify your guests of this update?" ● Add a banner at the top of the event editor: "Changes won't be sent unless you notify guests." ● Add a success confirmation after sending updates
"Text Blast" Feature Was Misunderstood or Overlooked	● Rename to "Notify Guests" or "Send Update" ● Add tooltips explaining its purpose ● Display confirmation: "Text sent to 5 guests"
Users Tried to Edit the Event From the Wrong Location	● Enable "quick edit" for key fields(e.g., time change,location change) from homepage menu ● If not feasible, guide users with a tooltip or label ● Ensure consistent icon labels across views
Allergy-Related Info Placed in Event Description Instead of RSVP or Food Section	● Improve onboarding or contextual help to show hosts how to add dietary questions to the RSVP questionnaire ● Clarify labeling of "+ Food Situation" (e.g., *"Event Food Info (e.g., BYOB, Theme)"*) ● Consider adding a labeling "+ Allergy Information"

	• Consider adding a dedicated prompt like: *"Would you like to ask guests about allergies or dietary needs in the RSVP?"*

Task 3	
Finding	**Recommendation**
Users Assumed Location Changes Automatically Notified Guests	• After location updates, prompt: *"Would you like to notify your guests of this change?"* • Show a confirmation banner: *"Update sent to all attendees"* or *"Guests have not yet been notified"*
Users Were Unable to Customize Cancelation of the Event	• Provide a post-cancellation summary (e.g., *"Event canceled and guests notified"*) • Allow a short custom note to be sent with the cancellation • Use a temporary "undo" option for recent cancellations

Task 4	
Finding	**Recommendation**
Users Did Not Realize Messaging Feature Existed	• Highlight messaging capability on guest profiles • Add a Call to Action, like *"Reconnect with guests"* after an event • Include a messaging icon in the event guest list • Allow the option for people to make their profile private if they do not want to use this feature
Users Were Uncertain Whether Messages Were Sent or Delivered	• Display "Message sent" feedback under the input field • Add inline error messages when sending fails (e.g., *"Please enter a message before sending"*) • Replace the red border with a more informative UI pattern

These recommendations aim to enhance the overall user experience on Partiful while supporting its growth and engagement across diverse audiences. By implementing these improvements, the app can better meet user needs, strengthen its brand presence, and continue to stand out in the competitive event-planning space.

Conclusion

Partiful succeeds in offering a fun, shareable way to organize social events, especially for younger, mobile-first users!

However, key usability issues emerged around:

- Public vs. private communication (e.g., RSVP comments and guest visibility)
- Lack of system feedback (e.g., no confirmation for text blasts or messages)
- Low feature discoverability (e.g., dietary inputs, messaging, update flows)
- Task completion was high, but users often felt uncertain or confused while performing actions.

These gaps may lead to:

- Missed or miscommunicated event details
- Reduced trust in the platform
- Workarounds through texting or external apps
- Improving visibility, feedback, and onboarding cues can help Partiful better support its mission:
  Helping people make friends (and memories) through confident interactions.

Contact Information

Prepared by:

Lumon Research Team

We’re excited to see where this goes! If you have any questions or need more information, please feel free to reach out to our research team:

Vipashyana Patel

Nicholas Mitchell

Gabrielle Orzech

Liz Almonte

Jackson Burke

Introduction

This protocol outlines the background, rationale, and procedures for a usability study conducted on the Partiful event planning platform. Developed by the Lumon Research consulting team, the study follows a structured approach to assess how effectively the app supports users in creating, managing, and attending social events. The protocol reflects the project's grounding in usability best practices, with a focus on observing real-world user behavior, identifying breakdowns in system interaction, and providing actionable recommendations.

Protocol Overview

Our team at Lumon Research was approached to conduct a usability study of Partiful, a digital invitation and event planning platform. Partiful supports both event hosts and guests, offering a playful and streamlined interface for sending invites, managing RSVPs, and engaging socially around upcoming events.

This protocol outlines the methodology used to evaluate the system's usability, trustworthiness, and discoverability across a range of realistic scenarios. As the platform targets casual event planning with an emphasis on social engagement, the user experience must balance creativity and ease-of-use with clear system feedback and control. Our approach includes structured task flows, role-specific interactions (host vs. guest), and reflective probes to capture both observed behavior and participant insights. Findings will help inform improvements to the app's design and user experience strategy.

Company Objectives

The founders of Partiful, Joy Tao and Shreya Murphy, aim to foster friendships through social events by creating a platform that makes it easy to connect with people you meet at parties.

Their core objectives include:

1. Making event planning fun and social
2. Building engagement and excitement around the event
3. Simplifying hosting and guest management through a streamlined RSVP process
4. Creating a social and and shareable experience using the community and post-event features

Ultimately, the Partiful team's goal is to create a fun, easy-to-organize event platform where guests can get to know one another without the hassle of connecting across multiple platforms.

Product Walkthrough

Partiful is a digital event planning and social invitation platform primarily used by young adults to create, share, and manage social gatherings. Partiful's value proposition lies in its emphasis on casual, socially engaging, and visually expressive event planning. It blends party hosting with digital storytelling, offering users a way to design themed invites, track RSVPs, and build community around events.

Partiful is accessible via mobile app or web browser, with most interactions optimized for the app experience. Its core user experience is centered around two primary roles:

- Event Hosts, who create and manage event pages
- Guests, who RSVP, view event details, and socially engage with others

Key features include:

- **Custom Event Creation**: Hosts can choose from event templates, upload custom images, name the event, and add details like time, location, and notes.
- **Smart Invite Distribution**: Invitations are sent via personalized text links. These links are one of the primary access points for users, especially first-time guests.

- **Guest Management & Visibility**: RSVP'd guests become part of a visible guest list. Depending on user actions, visibility of names and profiles may vary, raising interesting usability and privacy questions
- **Automated Messages**: Partiful sends reminders and hype messages to guests automatically unless the host disables or edits them.
- **Social Interaction Features**: Guests can leave comments, emojis, or upload photos and playlists, fostering a party-like atmosphere even before the event begins
- **Open Invites**: Users who have attended other Partiful events may receive recommendations for new events from familiar hosts, based on platform-inferred relationships.

Step 1: Access Partiful

- **Website:** Navigate to partiful.com and click on the purple "Create" button on the homepage.
- **Mobile App:** Download the Partiful app from the App Store or Google Play Store.

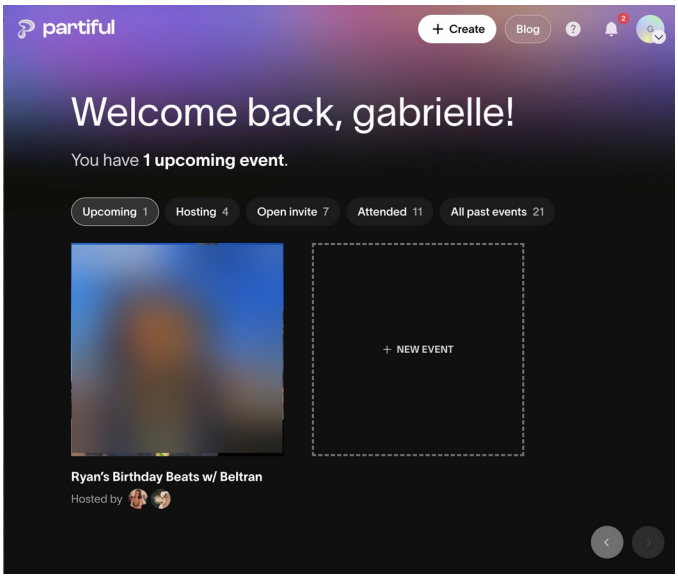


Figure 1. Web Home Page

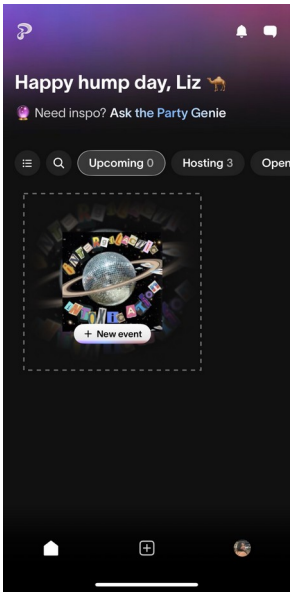


Figure 2. Mobile Home Page

Step 2: Create Your Event

1. Event Poster:

- Click the edit button on the default poster to choose a design that fits your event's vibe.
- Options include searching by event type (e.g., birthday, housewarming) or vibe (e.g., chill, summer).
- You can also upload your own image or use a GIF

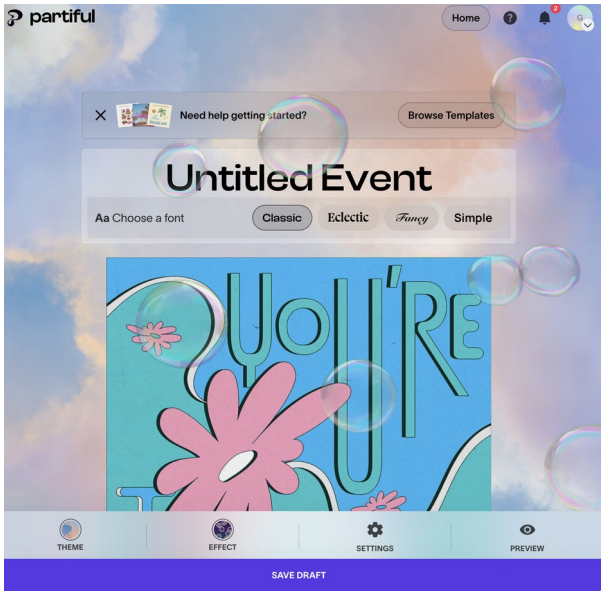


Figure 3. Web Invite Page



Figure 4. Mobile Invite Page

2. Event Details:

- **Name:** Enter a catchy title for your event.
- **Date & Time:** Specify when the event will take place.
- **Location:** Provide the venue's name, address, or a link.
- **Description:** Add any additional information or instructions for your guests.



Figure 5. Event Details Web Page

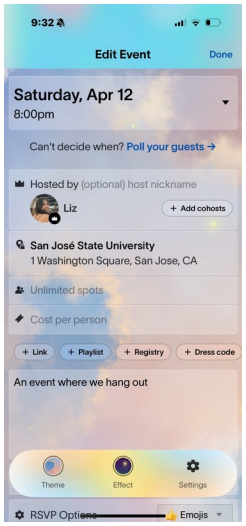


Figure 6. Event Details Mobile Page

3. Customization:

- **Theme:** Select a background that complements your event's aesthetic.
    - **Effects:** Add animations to make your invite more engaging.

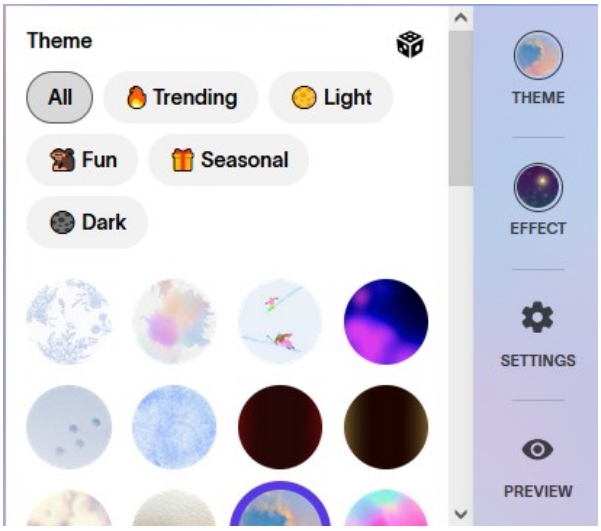


Figure 7. Customize Theme

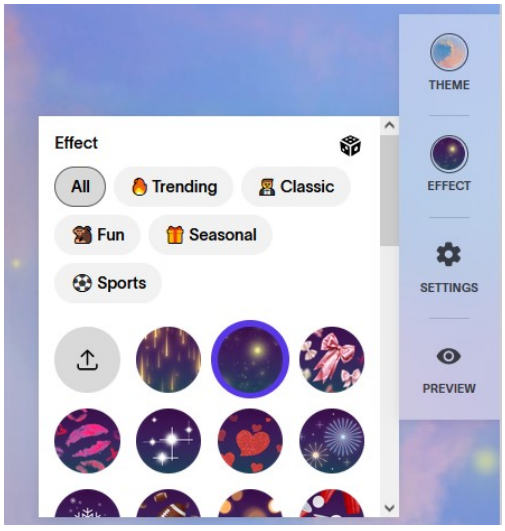


Figure 8. Customize Effects

4. Settings:

- Click on "Settings" to adjust various options:
  - Add co-hosts.
  - Set an RSVP limit.
  - Include a questionnaire for guests (e.g., dietary restrictions).
  - Enable payment collection via Venmo, Cash App, or PayPal.

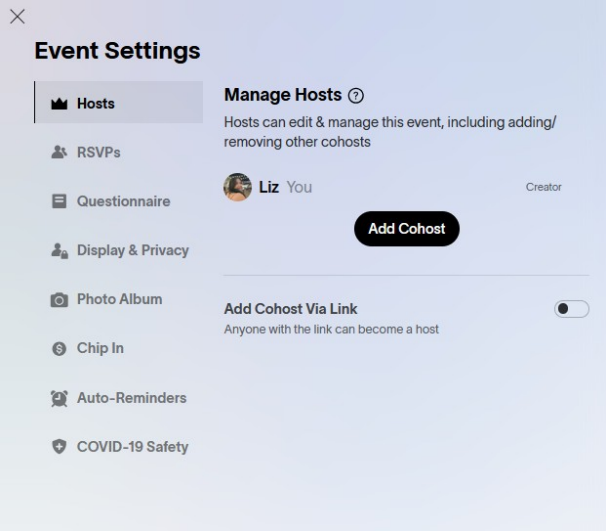


Figure 7. Web Event Setting

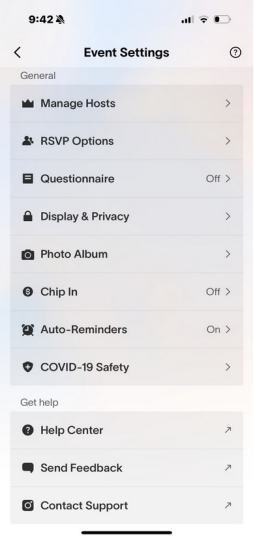


Figure 8. Mobile Event Settings

Step 3: Save and Share Your Event

- After finalizing the details, click "Save Draft" to generate your event page.
- **Inviting Guests:**
  - **Via Partiful:** Invite mutuals (people you've partied with before) directly through the platform; they'll receive a notification or text.
  - **Via Link:** Copy the event link and share it through text, email, or social media.

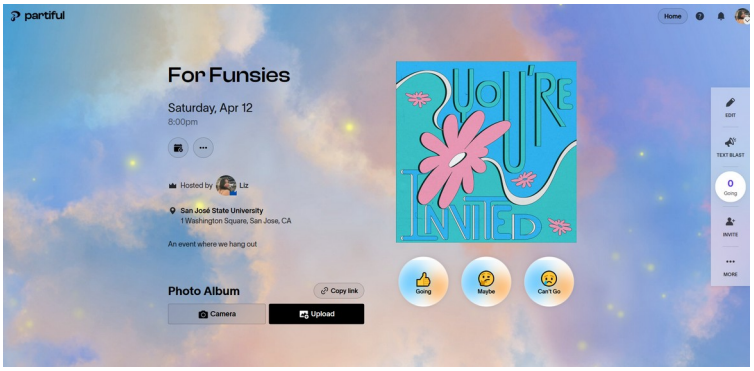


Figure 7. Generated Event Page

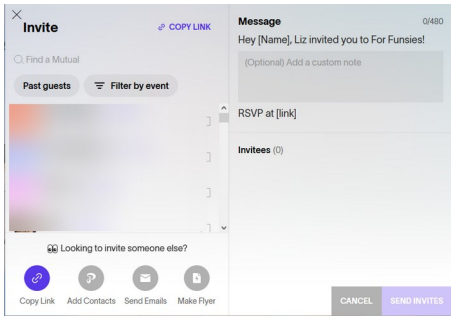
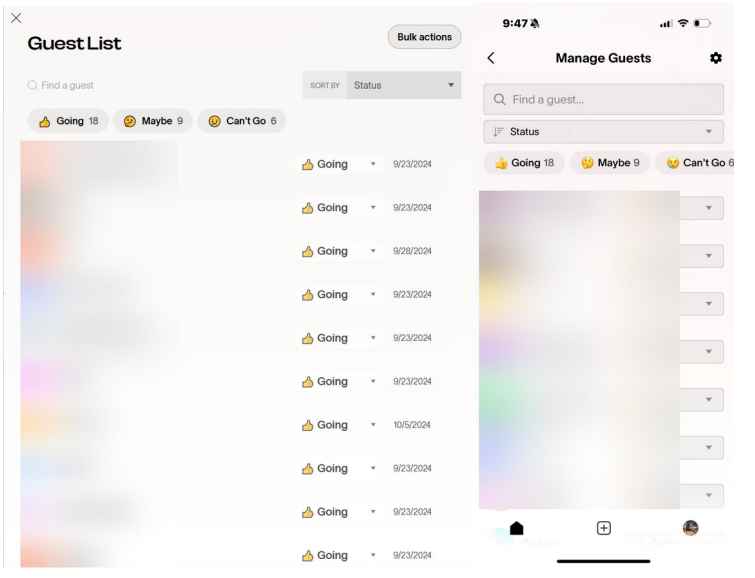


Figure 8. Send Invite Link Menu

Step 4: Manage Your Event

- **Guest List:** Monitor RSVPs and manage the guest list through the event page.
- **Communication:**
  - Use the "Text Blast" feature to send mass updates or reminders to all guests.
  - Guests can interact by leaving comments, posting photos, and replying to one another on the event page.



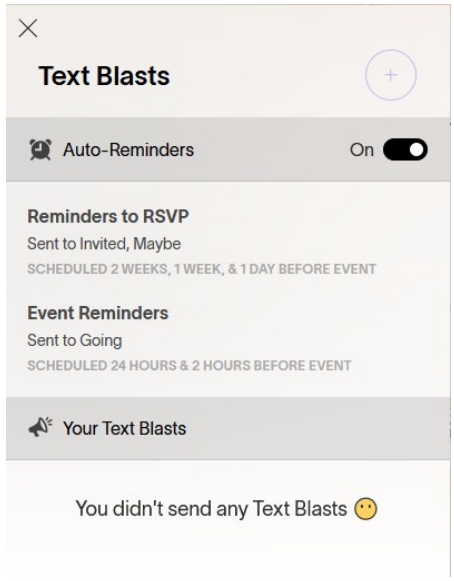


Figure 9. Web and Mobile Guest List Menu	Figure 10. Text Blast Menu

- **Post-Event:**
    - Create a shared photo album where guests can upload and view pictures from the event.

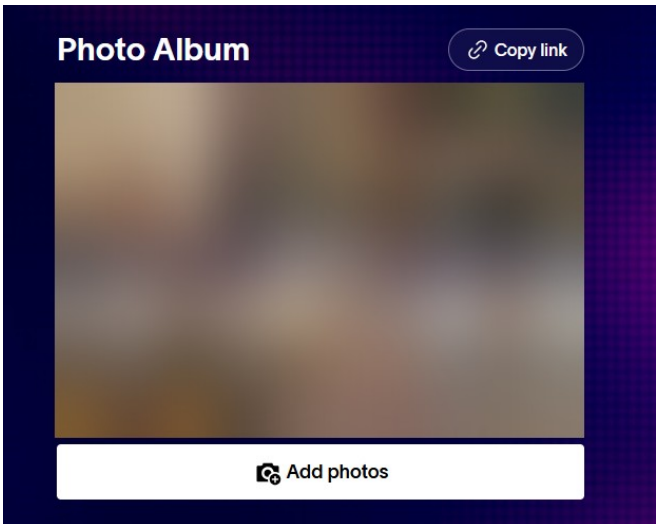


Figure 11. Shared Web Photo Album

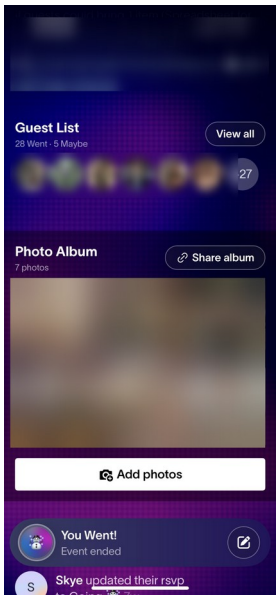


Figure 12. Shared Mobile Photo Album

Other Notable Features

- Mutuals - the **Mutuals** feature helps you keep track of people you've previously attended events with or invited to your own events.
    - **Attendees:** When you attend an event, all other attendees become your Mutuals.
    - **Hosts:** If you host an event, everyone you invite (including those who RSVP "Can't Go") becomes your Mutual.

- Open Invite - When you **enable Open Invite**, you're giving your guests permission to share the event with their own friends. Those friends can then RSVP and attend, even if they weren't directly invited by you.

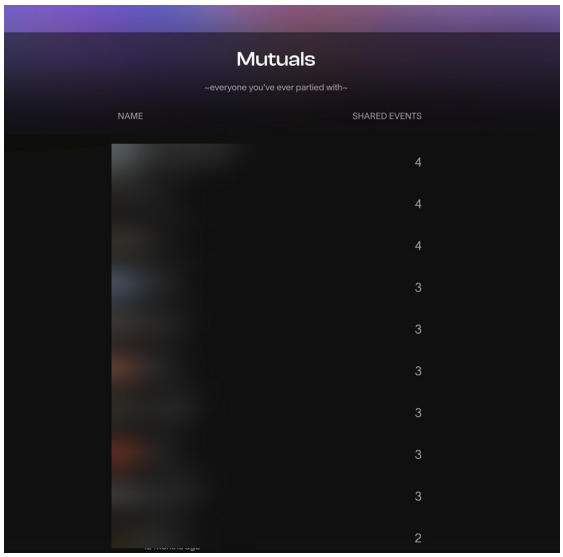


Figure 13. Mutuals Menu

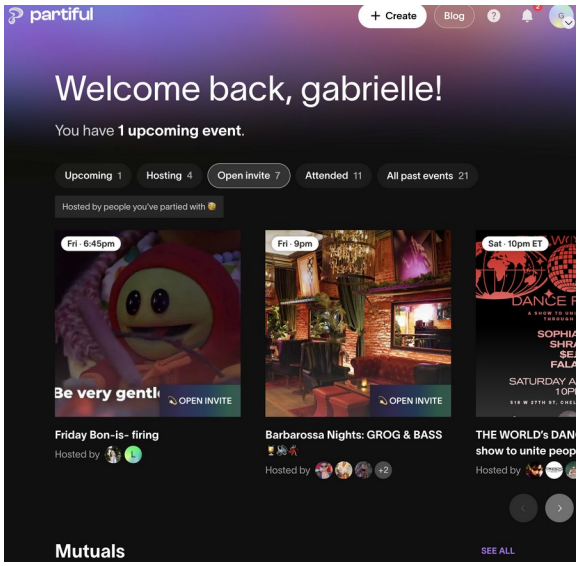


Figure 14. Open Invite Menu

  - Promotes the idea of inviting friends-of-friends

Use Context & Cases

Due to the app being accessible from multiple platforms, it is important to consider the use context. Below are scenarios to acknowledge while testing Partiful:

- Users have access to a **mobile device** or **desktop**
- Users have an **internet connection**
- Users are apart of a **group** or **organization**

- Users are looking to **make new connections**
- Users **plan events** or **social gatherings**
- Users want to be **given reminders** about the upcoming parties

Target Audience

Primary Demographic: Gen Z and Millennials (ages 18–35) who host or attend social events

Users:

- First-time Partiful users
- Repeat users who have hosted or attended at least one event
- Social organizers, college students, young professionals, partygoers

Use Contexts/Cases

Use Case 1: Hosting a party

Users, specifically the hosts, can manage invites, customize the theme of the party, and communicate with guests in one centralized place.

Use Case 2: Attending a Party

Users, specifically guests, are able to respond to an invite with a one-click RSVP via a mobile-friendly page with no account necessary. This allows them to see all the information needed for the party, as well as create engagement among other guests.

User Objectives:

Partiful not only caters to hosts, but to their guests as well. As a result, the user objectives explore two different perspectives, the hosts and the guests.

For Event Hosts

1. **Create and Customize Events**
    - Quickly and easily start an event from scratch.
    - Choose a fun design/theme that reflects the vibe of the event.
    - Add essential info (name, time, location, details) with clarity.
2. **Manage Invitations**
    - Easily invite friends through links or mutual connections.
    - Control visibility and guest access (e.g., private vs. public).
    - Set RSVP limits or deadlines if needed.
3. **Communicate with Guests**
    - Use group chat to share updates or build hype.
    - Send out reminders or mass messages (e.g., via text blast).
4. **Track Attendance and Engagement**
    - Monitor who has RSVP'd.
    - See if people are interacting with the invite (e.g., commenting, reacting).
5. **Post-Event Follow Up**
    - Encourage guests to upload photos.
    - Keep the vibe going even after the event wraps.

For Event Guests

1. **RSVP to an Event**
    - Quickly open an invite link and understand event details.

- RSVP with minimal steps and confidence that it worked.

2. **Understand the Event Info**
    - Easily find date, time, location, and any special instructions.
3. **Engage Socially**
    - Chat with other guests ahead of the event.
    - Add comments, reactions, or share pre-event excitement.
4. **Access and Share Event media**
    - Upload or view photos post-event.
    - Stay connected through the event's page even after it ends

Personas

Designing user personas requires a focus on what the core behaviors of the most common users when using Partiful. Rather than crafting a detailed background of a single user and explaining their reasons for using Partiful, we are basing the personas on caricatures of common scenarios that represent likely uses of the app.



Birthday Party Brianna:

It's Brianna's 30th birthday this Saturday and she wants to throw a fun party with friends to celebrate. Her apartment complex is difficult to park next to, so she puts parking instructions directed to a nearby lot. In the past she mentioned the party potentially happening on a different date, so she sends an announcement a couple days before to remind people of the correct date.



Frat Dude Frank:

Frank is the head of the frat Omega Eta Pi and loves to host the biggest ragers possible. He actively encourages +1's and makes his brother's co-hosts to share and help bump the attendance numbers. With how popular the parties get, he puts a $1 RSVP request to chip in for drinks, but makes it optional to keep people interested.



Holiday Dinner Hannah:

Hannah is throwing a potluck dinner to get in the holiday mood. She has a fairly small apartment and can only fit a max of 15 people, so she restricts the spots to 10 with a waitlist to make sure her best friends have room to attend. She links a spreadsheet to encourage a potluck style dinner, but makes sure to add a questionnaire during the RSVP to gather info on dietary restrictions.



Newbie Nate:

Nate was invited to a party through Partiful for the first time and now he wants to give it a try by hosting something for the Grammys. When making the event he set the date and time, thumbed through some themes and effects, then texted the link to some friends and didn't think too much more about it. People showed up when they were supposed to and Nate was happy.

Study Overview & Objectives

We begin by performing a preliminary review of the app guided by HF principles to identify any initial violations of usability or design. We will then use the information gained from this to guide the creation of our usability tests through the development of questions and probes seeking to , which will be driven by Partiful's objectives to further identify how users engage with the product and what pain points arise from these interactions.

Overall, our goal is to evaluate if users understand the system's purpose, how users make sense of the information provided to them by the app (if at all), and if they can

achieve the goals they set out to achieve when downloading/opening the app. We will be prompting them with two types of tasks. The first are knowledge-based tasks which were selected to assess the users mental models, system comprehension, and decision making processes. The second are performance-based tasks which focus on observable behavior and task execution. This would be making more quantitative measurements of efficiency, accuracy and error rates via tests like the NASA-TLX.

Our decision to use both forms of measurement reflects our objective to evaluate not only whether users can complete tasks successfully, but also whether they understand why or how certain actions affect system outcomes.

Internal Review Findings

Before developing our usability tasks, the Lumon Research team conducted an internal walkthrough of the Partiful platform to identify potential friction points. While the client had noted general concerns around RSVP workflows and guest interaction, our review uncovered additional areas of interest that informed our study design:

- **Privacy Ambiguity:** Users may not fully understand what personal information is visible to others on guest lists or post-event media pages. Partiful's "Mutuals" feature automatically links users who attend the same event. Once a user RSVPs and appears on the guest list their name and profile picture become visible to other attendees. These attendees can later see them listed under "Mutuals" and will receive them as suggested guests for future events. There is no option for a user to opt for this kind of exposure. While this may help build social connections, it presents privacy concerns in larger or mixed-attendance events where users may not expect their profile to be discoverable by others.

- **Event Cancellation Transparency:** Once guests RSVP, it's unclear how event changes or cancellations are communicated to them. Partiful does automatically notify guests when an event is canceled, but it is not explicit feedback to the host on click, or any option to customize or suppress the cancellation notification. This lack of transparency can cause confusion or hesitation for hosts who are unsure how their action will be perceived. The inability to quietly cancel an event may lead to awkward social dynamics, especially if a host is finalizing plans or simply trying to remove an event draft without alerting anyone.

- **Trust in Invite Links:** First-time users receiving a text link may perceive it as spam or be unsure about legitimacy and next steps. Additionally, without prior knowledge of the app, recipients may be unsure of what happens after clicking the link - whether they need to download the app to RSVP, create a profile, etc. This introduces friction during onboarding and can deter participation.

- **Automated Messaging Unawareness:** Hosts may not be aware that certain updates - such as changes to the event's date, time, or location are not automatically communicated to guests. Unless the host manually sends a message or announcement (e.g., Text Blast feature), guests may remain unaware of last-minute changes. As well, Hosts may not realize reminders and follow-up messages are sent automatically unless edited or turned off. This inconsistency creates a potential usability issue: users may form incorrect mental models about what kinds of communications are automated since some messages are sent without user awareness or intention, while others are not sent at all.

These findings helped guide our scenario selection and probe design, ensuring the usability study addresses both known and emergent issues relevant to real-world use.

Guiding Principles

To ensure this study is rooted in both practical insight and scientific theory, the Lumon Research team applies rigorous research methods drawn from cognitive science, user-centered design, and behavioral analysis. This table outlines the theoretical principles that guided our decisions during the study design. By aligning our methodology with these principles, we aim to collect actionable and scientifically sound insights for Partiful.

HF Concept	How It's Applied in This Study	Scientific Justification
Mental Models	Knowledge-based probes (e.g., "What do you think will happen if you cancel the event?")	Users' understanding of system functionality is shaped by their mental models. Misalignment can lead to errors or hesitation
Ecological Validity	Realistic scenarios (e.g., receiving invite via text, creating party with peanut allergy constraint)	Scenarios mimic actual use contexts, aligning with HF emphasis on real-world behavior
Cognitive Load	Participant feedback and NASA-TLX-style subjective ratings after tasks	Cognitive workload impacts usability and user satisfaction. Measuring perceived difficulty helps refine design
Social Desirability Bias	Moderator remains out of the room during task execution to reduce participant performance distortion	Reducing observer effects improves data integrity by minimizing the Hawthorne Effect
Adaptivity/ Filling the Circle	"Fill the Circle" philosophy - modifying probes and follow-ups based on participant behavior during session	Iterative design/testing aligns with *formative evaluation* principles in HF and HCD. It improves validity across diverse user contexts
Observational Data	AV recordings of task execution, facial expressions, non-verbal	Observation provides critical insights into user affect and

Collection	cues	behavior, beyond what is self-reported
Triangulation	Quantitative metrics (success rate) combined with qualitative data (interviews, behavior logs	Helps overcome the limitations of any single method by cross-validating insights from different data types

Team & Project Philosophy

Lumon research prides itself on conducting adaptive usability studies. We constantly iterate on our questions and procedures as the research proceeds by using the results from test users to inform our future decisions for future test users in the study. This lets us gain more knowledge and context to create better questions and narrow down on the points we find most significant or unexplored. This tactic of “filling the circle” is the crux of our testing strategy, and allows us to use a variety of methods to converge on a small set of insights.

In addition to the malleable prompts and probes used to gather the user’s opinion and perceived experience, an effective researcher can glean results from their data that were never explicitly uttered from a user, as their behavior and approach to a design can speak far more to what is occurring.

Our adaptive studies produce comprehensive results that paint a detailed picture of the different ways users intend to utilize the product for a given task(s), and how those goals are impeded or otherwise unrealized. The inevitable goal of our team is grounded in defining the core problem(s), as if you don’t accurately define the problem, the best you can do is solve the wrong problem well.

Methods

Personnel and Roles

The Lumon Research team consists of a Moderator, Data Logger, Receptionist, and AV Technician. All members of the team participated in recruitment, screening participants, scheduling the studies, and conducting the studies.

Receptionist:

The receptionist was the first point of contact of the participants with the team. They were contacted through phone screening. Pre-session, the receptionist greeted the participants, shared consent forms and confidentiality agreements, collected signatures on the forms, escorted the participants to the waiting area, and pointed out the location of refreshments, restroom and other amenities. Post-session, the receptionist confirmed follow-up communication details with the participants and processed the financial compensation.

Moderator:

The moderator interacted with the test participants directly. The moderator directed the participants through the usability testing when necessary. The moderator shared information about the testing before starting the process. They responded to any questions, helped clear doubts and assist the participants in case they ran into issues while completing the tasks.

Data Logger:

The data logger recorded behavioral observations of the participants through cameras set up in the testing room and supported the moderator for timed script and questions.

AV Technician:

The technician managed all 4 camera feeds and broadcasted the same into the client observation room from various angles. They controlled the varying focal points so that the videos can be reviewed later by the team for observations.

Participants

Recruitment

1. Types of Subjects

Participants were aged 18-35 who reflect the user base of the Partiful app.

2. Rationale for Subject Selection

This study aimed to evaluate the usability of Partiful for users who are likely to host or attend social events and interact with a digital invitation. Selecting users within this age group ensures alignment with the app's intended audience and creates a more ecological valid study. Participants included both first-time users and returning users, as well as those who have used the app in different roles (e.g., hosts and guests).

3. Number of Subjects

We recruited 30 participants to ensure diversity in roles and experience levels, with the understanding that actual participation may be lower due to scheduling conflicts. Setting a higher target helps account for dropouts and ensures we retain enough quality data for meaningful analysis.

4. Recruitment Methods

Recruitment was done through both physical and digital mediums, with flyers & posters being handed out/posted at or near event centers and at local businesses that promote social gathering, as well as across and around college campuses. Digitally, we sent direct emails to current users of the app, notifications to users with the app installed, and ad postings on social media platforms like Instagram and X. Recruiting material included information about the study, contact information, and link to a screener questionnaire. The researcher contacted eligible participants to schedule their first session.

- **Online:**
  - Email
  - Newsletters
- **Printed Materials**
  - Flyers for businesses
  - Posters for college campuses

5. Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

Inclusion Criteria:

- Adults aged 18-35
- Fluent in English

Exclusion Criteria:

- Individuals with significant visual or motor impairments that would impact mobile phone use

6. Screening Process

Participants completed an initial screening questionnaire online to assess eligibility. This included:

- Demographic information
- Smartphone and event app usage habits
- Experience with Partiful (if any)

During the start of the session, participants completed the following:

a. Informed Consent Form
b. A demographic questionnaire (age, gender, tech comfort level, role with Partiful, etc.)

7. Communications

Participants were contacted via email to schedule their usability session and receive logistical details (location, reminders, schedule).

8. Payment

Participants received $150 cash upon completion of the session.

Study Design

Timeline and Procedures

Each session lasted 70 minutes and follow a structure of:

1. Welcome and study overview
2. Informed Consent
3. Demographic questionnaire
4. Brief warm-up and introduction to the app
5. Usability tasks
6. Post-task subjective ratings and interviews
7. Debrief and Compensation

2. User Background

While we are not assigning participants to strict test conditions, we took note and documented each participant's background based on their screener responses. Participants were categorized post hoc into the following informal usage levels:

- First-Time Users: Participants with no prior exposure to the Partiful app
- Casual Users: Participants who have interacted with Partiful as guests only or used it once
- Experienced Users: Participants who have hosted events or used the app multiple times.

This allows us to observe how experience level impacts task performance, navigation, efficiency, and feedback without introducing formal conditions that would require separate test designs.

3. Participant Matrix

To ensure representation across key user roles and experience levels, a participant tracking matrix was used as a flexible planning tool throughout the study. Rather than assigning participants to rigid testing groups, we tracked participant backgrounds based on their screener responses and dynamically adjust session flows as appropriate. This allows us to observe how different user types, first-time guests, casual users, and experienced hosts, approach the platform, while preserving the fluid, natural behavior that arises during real-world use.

We recognize that participants may not fit neatly into predefined categories, and their behaviors may evolve as they explore the app. In line with our "fill the circle"

methodology, we used early sessions to identify areas of divergence and curiosity, then iterate on future task paths, probe questions, and scenarios to dive deeper into emerging usability concerns. This ensured that each participant contributes not only to our core questions, but also to the discovery of new insights that help close the loop on Partiful's design assumptions.

Participant ID	Role	Experience Level	Tasks Assigned
P01	Guest only	First-time	RSVP, guest list, Open Invite
P02	Host	Returning	Create event, cancel, add guests, edit details
P03	Guest + Host	First-time host	RSVP, create event, send invite, cancel
P04	Host	Experienced	Poll guest, automate reminders, manage org

4. Scenarios

The scenarios in the study have been designed to reflect realistic contexts in which users might interact with the Partiful app. These included both hosting and attending events, as well as first-time and returning user experiences. Scenarios are based on

common social behaviors of the app, such as receiving an invite via text, creating an event as an individual, and managing guest interactions. By having these tasks anchored to real world situations the study captured how users interpret, navigate, and respond to features in a more ecological valid way.

Simulated Invite Link:

The participant was sent a test event invite via text message. We observed how they interpret the invite, whether they click, RSVP, or create a profile.

Goal of this scenario: designed to explore trust, onboarding clarity, and perceived legitimacy.

First Time Event Creation:

A participant is asked to create an event for a dinner party. They were told to personalize the theme, set a time, and invite 3 friends.

Goals: Evaluate ease of event creation, discoverability of customization options, and mental model alignment for first-time hosts

Event Cancellation After RSVPS:

The participant was asked to cancel an event after others have RSVP'd

Goal: Explore user awareness of how cancellation affects guests, and whether the interface communicates this clearly.

Reconnecting with someone the participant met:

The participant was told they met someone at a previous party and they hit it off with them. They would like to reconnect with that person, and do not have their contact information.

Goal: Observe user understanding of this feature, and connect through the application.

5. Tasks

Participants were not formally assigned to formal test groups, but they may complete slightly different task flows based on their real-world role or experience with the app.

All participants completed core shared tasks (e.g., exploring an invite, attempting RSVP), but additional tasks (e.g., event cancellation, creating polls) were introduced where appropriate based on participant background. Observations were analyzed for usability issues and patterns across roles, rather than group comparisons.

See Script design for complete task breakdown

6. Probes

We included a set of probing questions that were administered during the study session. Based on observing the participant, we asked a variety of questions unique to their behavior and performance to help fill the circle of information. Some of these questions were as follows:

- What do you think will happen if you cancel this event?
- Do you know who will receive this message or notification?
- Were you aware of the automated reminders that get sent out?
- What do you think Open Invite means?
- If you lost access to this link, how would you get back in?
- Did you feel in control of what information was shared?
- Were there any features you felt nervous or uncertain about?

SETUP:

- Print consent form & task sheets for participant to reference
    - (make sure to exclude tester notes like the “Text Blast” comments)
- Set out iPad or laptop to include vision of participant face-forward, along with portions of the app.
- Elect one tester’s phone to be the usability device.
- Run Discord and stream the screen in a voice call.
- Join the call on the note taker’s laptop.
- Run snipping tool and record the portion of Discord that has the stream running.
    - MAKE SURE to switch it from camera to video
    - (just need to move window over to side, doesn’t need to take up full screen)
- Open record sheets to be ready to record data.
    - (or just a google docs if it hasn’t been created…)
- Gather any other note-taking tools needed.
- Begin recording on both the iPad and laptop screen recording.
- Moderator begins with the script.

Script Design

Session Intro:
Hello [Participant Name], Thanks again for joining us today, and welcome to the session. My name is [Facilitator Name], and I am part of the research team at Lumon Research. We are here to learn more about how people interact with Partiful, an event-planning and invitation app. This study helps us identify what is working well

and where the app could be more intuitive or user-friendly.

Before we get started, I want you to take a few moments to take a look over our consent form and sign at the bottom. If you are uncomfortable or there is any reason you would need to stop early you have the right to do so.

First, this is not a test of you. We are evaluating the product, not your abilities.

Second, there are no right or wrong answers. Take your time during each task. If you get stuck or take a different path than expected, that is completely okay.

Today's session will last about 45 minutes. During that time, we will walk through a few realistic event scenarios using the app. After the tasks, I will ask you a few short questions about your experience.

When we are finished, you will receive $5 in cash as a thank-you for your time and participation.

If you have any questions during the session, feel free to ask. However, I may not answer right away so that I do not influence your choices.

Does that all sound good? If so, we can begin.

Script 1: First-Time Guest – RSVP & Privacy Exploration

Scenario:	“Your close friend Alex is turning 26 and is hosting a birthday party this weekend! Alex texted you an invite link using Partiful. You’ve never used Partiful before, but you’d love to go and celebrate. You’re vegetarian and want to make sure Alex knows this. You’re curious how much personal information other guests might see about you.”
Tasks:	1. Open the link Alex sent via text. 2. RSVP to the event, noting your vegetarian dietary preference. 3. Check the event’s date, time, and location.
Knowledge-Based Probes:	● What do you think happens after you RSVP? ● What personal information do you expect others can see about you? ● Would you feel safe and comfortable responding to invitations this way regularly?
Performance-Based Observations:	● Ease and time to RSVP and specify dietary restrictions. ● User confidence navigating personal information visibility.
Post-Task Interview	● Did the app make it clear how your information would be shared? ○ Do you think how the app presented itself made the creation of the event easier or harder? ■ If so, why is that?

	• Were there any points of confusion or concern regarding your privacy? • How intuitive was your first experience using the invitation?

Script 2: First-Time Host – Creating and Adjusting an Event

Scenario:	"You're helping a friend throw a small get-together at their apartment this Friday night at 6:00pm. Since their apartment isn't very large, you can only comfortably accommodate about 8 people. Their friend Sarah has a severe peanut allergy, so you must ensure the guests don't bring peanut-based snacks to the party. After posting the event, you realize it needs to start 30 minutes later than planned, and now you have to update everyone about this change to the event." Your friend's address is 4960 National Ave.
Tasks:	1. Create your event on Partiful and choose a theme that matches your casual gathering. 2. Organize the event specifications to the prompt above. 3. Clearly communicate the peanut allergy restriction to

	your guests. 4. Distribute the invitations 5. After creating your event, adjust the start time by moving it 30 minutes later — Ask performance-Based Observation Q's here — 6. (Moderator): Inquire about the time adjustment. Ask if the subject believes the party goers are aware of the time change that happened in the app a. (try your best to not be suggestive, although hard) 7. Demonstrate how you would notify guests of this updated start time.
Knowledge-Based Probes:	● How clearly do you think your guests will understand the peanut allergy restriction? ● How do you anticipate your guests will be aware of the updated start time? ○ Here is where we mention the truth if they missed it. This lets us inquire WHY they missed it, what they expected (what was expected from updating? Lack of a button for it?) ● NOW Inquire about Text Blast: ○ Did you see it? ■ What did you think it was *supposed* to be

	● (What would you think it was if we hadn't asked?) ○ Did you see the navigation bar? ■ Possibly inquire why they think that is. ● (participant usually blames self here, but might be worth asking depending on the person). ○ What do you think it WILL do if you used it? (without tapping on it.) ■ Then let them tap on it, see what was different from their mental model.
Performance-Based Observations:	● Time, ease, and potential difficulties faced in event creation and updating. ● Whether participants intuitively discover the communication tools available in Partiful (such as the Text Blast).
Post-Task Interview	● Did you *initially* feel confident that guests received notifications about changes? ● Was customizing the event and communicating restrictions straightforward? ● What would you expect from a feature like this? ○ What would you want in a feature like this?

Script 3: Experienced Host – Managing Venue Changes & Cancellations

Scenario:	“You often use Partiful for organizing club meetups, and this weekend, you planned a local hiking event with about 20 RSVPs. However, heavy rain in the forecast means you have to change the meeting point to a sheltered picnic area instead. Later, due to worsening weather predictions, you unfortunately have to cancel the event entirely. You want to make sure your guests clearly understand these last-minute adjustments and cancellations.”
Tasks:	1. Navigate to your existing hiking event and update the meeting location to the picnic shelter. 2. Demonstrate how you would notify your guests about this location change. 3. After notifying them, you decided to completely cancel the event. 4. Confirm the event cancellation and manage the notifications sent to your guests.
Knowledge-Based Probes:	● After updating the event location, how confident are you that guests will be aware of the change? ● Upon cancellation, how clear do you expect the communication to be about the cancellation?
Performance-Based Observations:	● The participant’s intuitive approach to communicating changes and event cancellation. ● Ease of updating details and clarity of cancellation process.

	• Whether the participant naturally uses or identifies the Text Blast option.
Post-Task Interview	• Did you feel assured that your guests were promptly notified about these event changes? • Did the app adequately convey the impact and visibility of your event updates and cancellations? • Did any aspect of managing event changes or cancellations feel confusing or challenging from a usability or communication perspective?

Script 4: Reconnecting with a New Friend from a Past Event

Scenario:	*"Last weekend, you went to a party hosted through Partiful. It was a really fun night, and while you were there, you hit it off with someone named Vipashna. You talked for a while, shared similar interests, and really wanted to keep in touch—but the night flew by, and you never exchanged contact info. You don't have any mutual friends, and now you're hoping you can find a way to reconnect through the app."*
Tasks:	1. Open Partiful and try to connect with Vipashna. 2. Look for a way to view the guest list or people who attended. 3. Try to find Vipashna from that event. 4. See if there is a way to message them directly through the app.

	5. Send them a short message saying it was great to meet them and you'd love to reconnect.
Knowledge-Based Probes:	● How confident are you that this person will receive your message? ● What do you think happens when you send a message through Partiful? ● Was it clear who you're allowed to message or view from past events?
Performance-Based Observations:	● Can the participant successfully locate the past event and guest list? ● Did they discover the messaging feature on their own? ● Any hesitation or confusion? ● Do they make assumptions about feature placement, accessibility, or visibility?
Post-Task Interview	● Was it easy or difficult to find someone from a past event? ● Did the process feel natural or awkward in any way? ● Did you have any concerns about whether they would receive the message or how they'd perceive it? ● Where did you expect those features to be, and how did that compare to where they were? ● Would you be likely to use this feature again after an event?

Post-Test Interview:

- Which of the tasks today were the most unintuitive to understand or execute?
    - How so?
- Is there anything that made you concerned about your privacy when using the app?
- Do you think that Partiful has opened opportunities ***via the app*** to connect and build friendships with fellow partygoers?
    - Why or why not?
- Do you think there are ways for the app to better allow you to achieve these goals?
- Is there anything about the app that Partiful achieves that other products don't?
- What aspects of this app did you enjoy?
- What parts of it do you think they could improve?
- What features or aspects of this app were you expecting but didn't find?\
- Would you use this product again?
    - Why or why not?

Metrics and Measures

For each task assigned, we collected both quantitative and qualitative data based on our goals: efficiency, effectiveness and user satisfaction. The following usability study measures were employed:

	Metrics	Goals
Performance	● Time on task ● Discovery of user paths ● Navigation accuracy ● Task error rates ● Task abandonment rates ● Task completion success rate ● Selection accuracy	● Tasks are completed in minimum time ● Tasks paths are easily discovered ● Minimum number of clicks to complete tasks ● Tasks are completed successfully

Objective (Behavioral)	• Non-verbal signs of confusion or difficulty • Time spent on exploring the screen for possible path • Time spent on reading and revisiting instructions • Help of support use	• Participant is satisfied with the hosting/accepting events on the website • No additional assistance is requested on the screen
Subjective (Verbal)	• Indicating ease of use • Satisfaction Rating • Unprompted talk aloud (If natural)	• Reasonable learning curve to use the website • No visible signs of confusion or difficulty in accomplishing the tasks

Severity Rating Framework

To prioritize usability issues uncovered during testing, we applied a structured severity rating system adapted from Jakob Nielsen's usability severity scale. Each finding was assessed using the following four dimensions:

1. **Frequency** – How many users encountered the issue during testing
2. **Impact** – The extent to which the issue interfered with task completion or trust
3. **Persistence** – Whether the issue is likely to reoccur unless addressed
4. **Recoverability** – Whether users could easily recover or work around the issue

Severity Levels Used in This Report

- 🔴 **High** – Critical usability breakdowns that frequently led to user confusion, task failure, or exposed personal information; must be addressed
- 🟡 **Medium** – Noticeable friction that slowed users down or increased cognitive effort, but users could recover or complete the task

- 🟢 **Low** – Cosmetic or uncommon issues that had minimal impact on usability

This severity framework ensured that even if an issue was experienced by only one participant, it could still be rated as high severity if it posed a substantial usability or trust risk. Conversely, commonly seen minor issues were rated medium or low if they were easy to recover from.

Testing Facility

Set Up & Staging

Below is the user testing facility. It is located in downtown San Jose. Address: 500 N Santa Clara & First St, San Jose, CA.

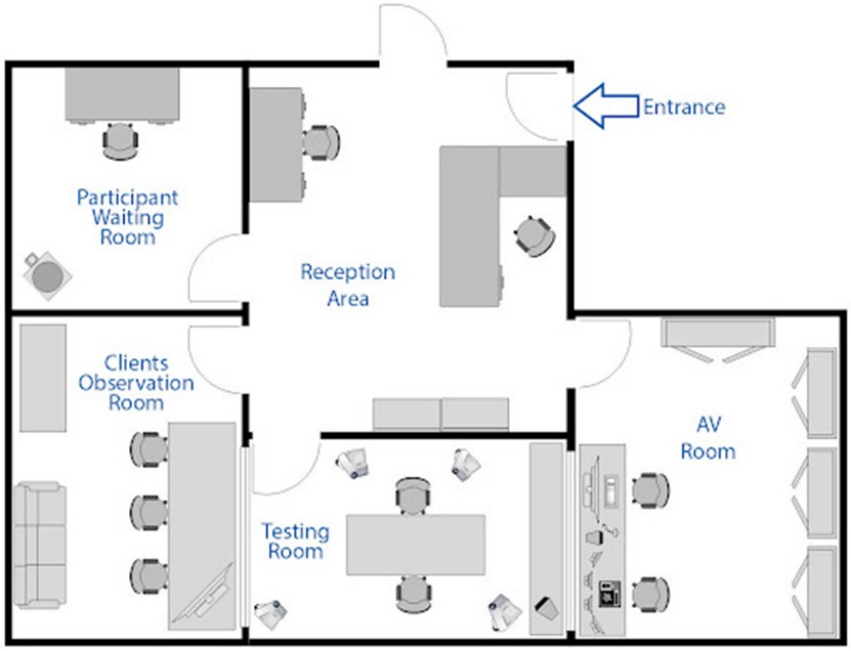


Figure: Floor plan of the user research lab in San Jose.

The User Testing Laboratory was set up for one participant, one moderator and 4 observers. Equipment include computers with reliable access to the internet and 4 cameras for recording the user's interaction in the participant room. Live feed was recorded from the testing room at various angles and focus points. These cameras captured the participants' non-verbal behavioral language like body language and facial expressions. The AV room and client observation room are adjacent to the testing room

on the opposite side. They are separated by the testing room with one-way mirrors that facilitate the observation.

The AV Room was staffed with a camera technician and a data logger. The technician had full control over the video cameras. The data logger recorded the observations and responses during the session. The AV Room is equipped with storage units to store the equipment after use, access to wifi, power outlets, desktops/laptops, chairs and desks. Members from the Lumon Research team may or may not be present briefly during the sessions.

The observation room is equipped with a wide screen display set up to stream video from the testing room, three chairs, couch, desks, power outlets, access to guest wifi, desktops/laptops and refreshments. The room is big enough to accommodate three guests, client team members and Lumon Research team members.

Procedure

The Lumon Research team followed a standardized checklist for setting up the testing room, administering the session, and resetting the space before the next participant. This structured approach ensures consistency, data integrity, and participant comfort across all usability test sessions.
Before each session, team members ensured that:

- Overhead and spotlighting are functional
- AV equipment and screen recordings are properly configured
- The Partiful site is open in a clean browser state (no other tabs or apps running)
- Internet connectivity is stable and sufficient for testing

The AV Technician verified that the four camera feeds are recording and transmitting to the observation room, and the data logger prepared a digital template to document observations.
When participants arrived, the receptionist greeted them, provided the Informed Consent Form, and answered any logistical questions. Once paperwork is signed, participants are escorted to the waiting room until their scheduled start time.

The moderator then brought the participant into the testing room and provided a brief study introduction.

For the predefined task section, the moderator observed remotely via live video feed rather than being physically present in the room. This approach reduces the risk of social desirability bias, where participants may alter their behavior due to perceived social pressure or observation. By creating a more natural setting, this method encourages authentic interactions with the system while still allowing the moderator to flag moments of confusion, hesitation, or interest for follow-up.

Following the task segment, the moderator re-entered the room to conduct a brief targeted discussion of key observed moments, followed by the unscripted exploration phase, where participants are invited to navigate freely within the Partiful interface.

After concluding the session:

- The participant was escorted back to the reception area
- Compensation of $150 was provided
- The testing room and equipment was disinfected
- The browser and environment was reset

- All recordings were be securely saved and labeled by the AV Technician

This procedure was repeated for each participant, with the checklist verified and signed off before the next session begins.

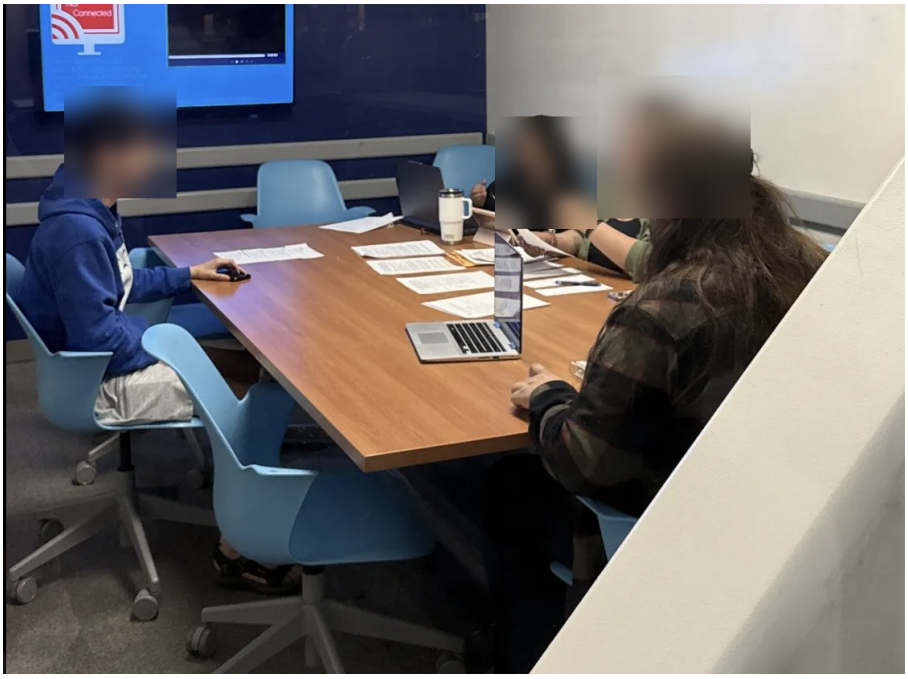
Session Schedule

	Session Description	Duration
Check-In & Consent	Participant is greeted by the receptionist, receives an overview of the study, and completes the informed consent and confidentiality agreement. A short demographic questionnaire is completed if not already submitted.	5 minutes
Moderator Introduction	The moderator introduces themselves and provides the task instructions based on the script and scenarios they've been selected to. The moderator then exits the testing room for the next segment to reduce social desirability bias.	5 minutes
Predefined Task Session	Participants complete structured tasks (e.g., RSVP, event creation, editing details) while being observed via remote AV feed. Moderators and data loggers monitor behavior in real time to flag confusion points or unexpected behavior. No direct intervention is made during this portion.	30 minutes
Clarification & Interview	The moderator re-enters the room to conduct a short follow-up discussion focused on key moments observed during the task portion. Participants are invited to reflect on their actions, expectations, and any points of confusion. This bridges observable behavior with internal reasoning.	15 minutes

Unscripted Exploration	Participants are given a brief prompt to explore the Partiful interface freely. This stage helps identify discoverability issues and user curiosity without formal task constraints.	10 minutes
Debrief & Wrap-Up	The moderator wraps up the session with a final reflection question and thanks the participant. The receptionist escorts the participant back to the waiting area and provides $100 compensation. Equipment is reset and sanitized for the next session.	5 minutes

Study Observations & Findings

The following section presents usability findings from each of the four core tasks evaluated during testing. Observations are organized by task and include the identified issue, its severity, the heuristics it violates, behavioral or verbal evidence from participants, and a design recommendation. Each finding represents a breakdown in the user experience that impacted efficiency, trust, or task success



Task 1: RSVP & Dietary Preferences

Task Overview:

Participants received a sample event invitation via text message and were asked to RSVP. During this process, we observed how they provided dietary information, submitted RSVP comments, and interpreted what information would be visible to the host and other guests. This task allowed us to evaluate trust, clarity, and information flow in the early stages of guest interaction.

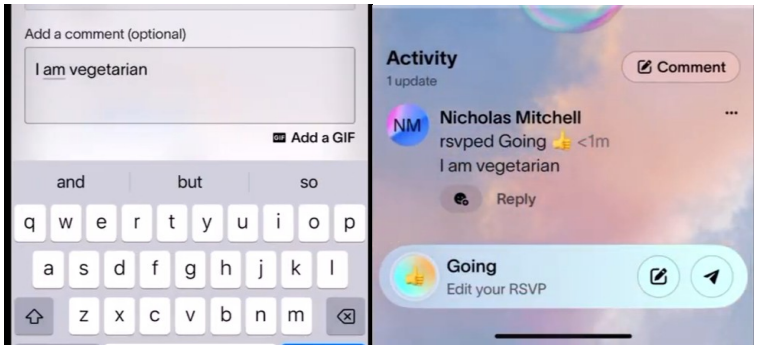
Participant	Task 1: What They Did	Time on Task	Task Completed
P1	Assumed the comment box to be private space for sharing dietary preferences.	1:39.38	Yes
P2	Asked if there was a separate input for selecting dietary preferences.	2:18.66	Yes

P3	Asked for clarification if the dietary preference was to be noted, because he recognized that comment box was public.	1:27.81	Yes
P4	Missed and were confused by dietary input options.	1:10.35	Yes
P5	Did not recognize the dietary questionnaire.	0:59.35	Yes

Task 1: Finding 1 - Comment Box Misused for Dietary Information

Description:

All five participants entered dietary restrictions into the public RSVP comment field rather than the designated input. Most believed they were sending a private message to the host, but the comment was posted publicly on the event page.



User Quotes:

“Just typing in vegetarian should be fine, right?”

“I would like to put it as an option rather than a custom field…”

Heuristics Violated: **Severity:** 🔴 High

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
RSVP comment box used for allergies	Match Between System & Real World	Field placement and labeling did not match user expectations for input type
No error prevention for allergy terms	Error Prevention	System didn’t redirect or warn when allergy info was entered in the wrong field

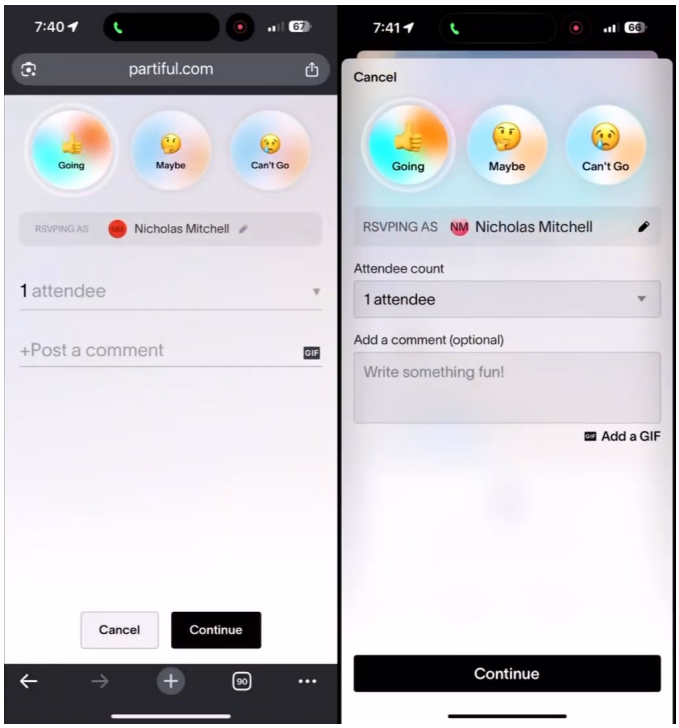
This finding highlights a critical failure in guiding user behavior. By placing the dietary field on a page after the comment box, the system led users to unintentionally share sensitive information in the wrong location. This introduces both privacy concerns and practical risks, such as a host missing allergy info that wasn’t entered in the intended field. The error reflects a poor match between the system’s layout and the user’s mental model.

Recommendations:

- When added by host, move dietary input field above the RSVP comment field
  Add a placeholder to the comment box like “Write a greeting for the event feed (public)”
- Trigger a warning if allergy-related terms are detected in the comment field

Task 1: Finding 2 - RSVP Comments Assumed to Be Private

Description: 3 out of 5 participant**s** assumed that the RSVP comment box was a private message to the host. None realized that their messages would be publicly visible to all other guests. Multiple users hesitated before submitting, visibly unsure about who would see their response.



User Quotes:

"Is it showing this to everyone? I don't mind, but I'm curious."

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🔴 High

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
No feedback on comment visibility	Visibility of System Status	Users had no system cues confirming where their message would appear
Labeling didn't guide correct behavior	Recognition Rather Than Recall	Users had to guess whether their comment was private or public

This issue centers on audience misperception. When users believe they are privately messaging a host but instead post publicly, it erodes trust in the platform and makes them less likely to use in-app communication. It also introduces social friction, as users may overshare or censor themselves due to unclear boundaries between public and private interaction.
If Partiful's goal is to create fun, casual, guest-friendly experiences, clarity about who sees what is fundamental to preserving user confidence and comfort.

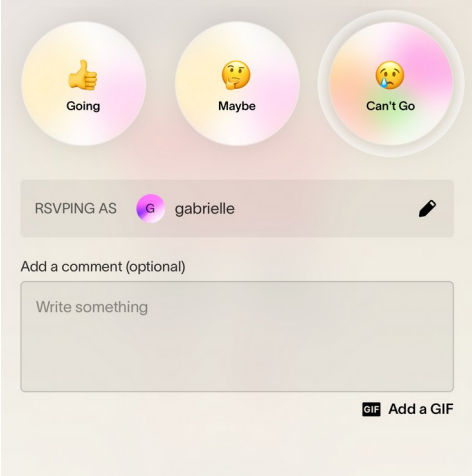
Recommendation:

- Add label: "This comment is visible to all guests"
- Show a comment preview before submission

- Offer a separate host-only message field

Task 1: Finding 3 - Uncertainty About What Info is Shared With Others

Description: Participants were unsure which piece of RSVP information- such as name, profile photo, RSVP status - would be visible to hosts vs. guests. This uncertainty affected comfort with submitting info.



When RSVPing, it's not entirely clear what information is shared with whom (host vs. guests)

User Quotes:

> "I don't think my information is shared."
> "Other than my preference, I don't know if they'll be able to see anything else."

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🟡 Medium

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
Unclear who sees what in RSVP flow	Visibility of System Status	Users lacked system feedback about data visibility, leading to hesitation and doubt
No labels or previews showing shared fields	Recognition Rather Than Recall	Users had to guess what others would see, rather than being clearly informed

When users are unsure which RSVP details are public or private, they withhold information, second-guess themselves, or resort to outside communication (e.g., texting the host). This slows down engagement and disrupts the flow of using Partiful as a full event communication tool.
More importantly, this reflects a system-wide opacity problem. If users don't know what data is shared and when, they may assume the worst or avoid using the platform entirely for sensitive inputs.

Recommendation:

- Add an “info” icon near RSVP fields explaining visibility (“Host only” vs “All guests”)
- Show a short summary of what info will be shared on submission screen

Task 2: Creating & Editing Events

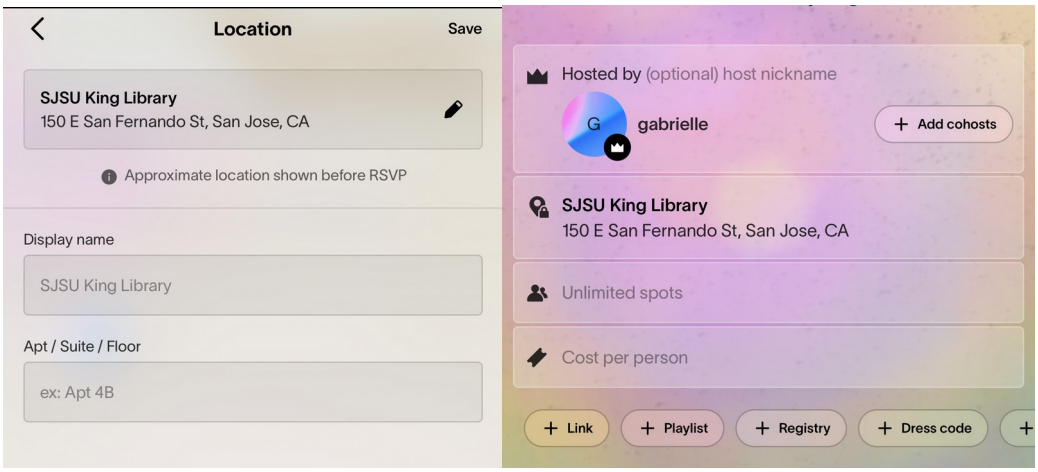
Task Overview:

Participants were asked to act as a host by creating a new event in Partiful. They were instructed to customize the event, add important information (such as a dietary restriction), and then later edit the event time. This task evaluated the discoverability of customization features, the clarity of update processes, and how well the platform supported user expectations around communicating changes to guests.

Participant	Task 2: What They Did	Time on Task	Task Completed
P1	Edited time without notifying guests.	3:51.30	Yes
P2	Assumed notifications would go out automatically.	2:21.56	Yes
P3	Attempted to edit time via the wrong menu (3-dot menu on homepage).	04:52.19	Yes
P4	Confused and unsure about the "Text Blast" feature.	03:06.22	Yes
P5	Overlooked text blast feature.	03:27.62	Yes

Task 2: Finding 1 - Users Did Not Realize Guests Wouldn’t Be Notified After Edits

Description: After editing the event time, 4 out of 5 participants failed to notify guests, either assuming it would happen automatically or not realizing it was required. This resulted in critical miscommunication about event logistics.



No feedback given after clicking save

User Quotes:

“I thought it would just notify everyone automatically.”
“There wasn’t anything that told me to do that.”

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🔴 High

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
No prompt to send update	Visibility of System Status	Users had no confirmation that changes were sent or needed to be manually sent
Update flow lacked control cues	User Control and Freedom	Users assumed system behavior rather than choosing it — reducing reliability

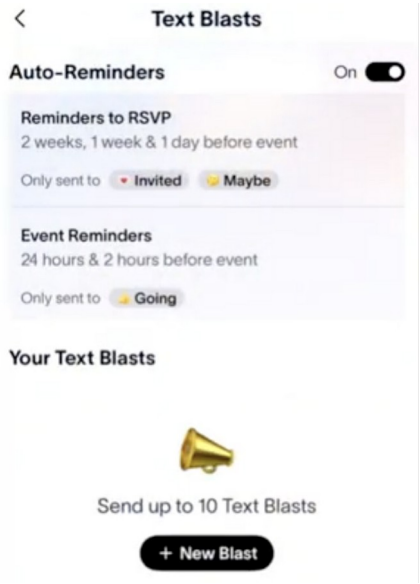
This is a core communication failure. If users assume guests are notified when they aren’t, it creates major planning issues and undermines trust in the platform. It also creates extra follow-up work for the host that they may not realize is needed.

Recommendation:

- Prompt users after time/location changes: “Would you like to notify your guests of this update?”
- Add a banner at the top of the event editor: “Changes won’t be sent unless you notify guests.”
- Add a success confirmation after sending updates

Task 2: Finding 2 - “Text Blast” Feature Was Misunderstood or Overlooked

Description:
Most users were unsure what the “Text Blast” feature did. The term felt unfamiliar, and the UI didn’t offer clear feedback about whether it had been used successfully.



There is limited information on what a “text blast” means beyond auto reminders

User Quotes:
“Can I just use this whenever?”
“I think I sent it? It didn’t say anything.”

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🟡 Medium

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
No label clarification	Consistency & Standards	“Text Blast” isn’t intuitive and doesn’t follow naming conventions for notifications
No confirmation of delivery	Visibility of System Status	Users didn’t know if the message was sent, reducing trust in the feature
Lack of onboarding cues	Recognition Rather Than Recall	The feature wasn’t surfaced or explained where users expected it

“Text Blast” is a mission-critical feature, but it’s poorly named and unsupported by visual feedback. If users hesitate or avoid using it, essential updates won’t be delivered. Worse, if they *do* use it but receive no confirmation, they’re left questioning the reliability of the system.

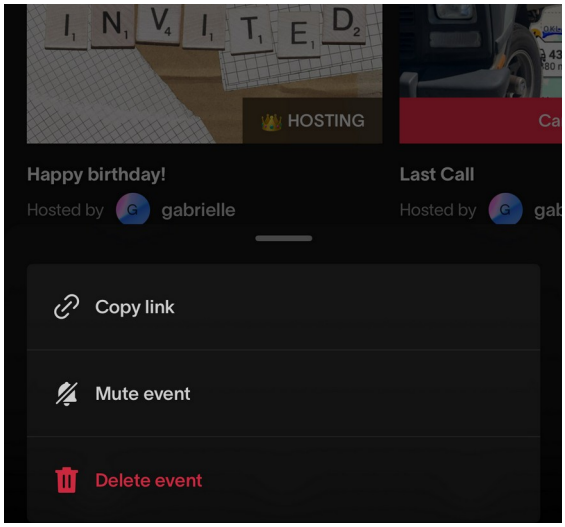
For new users especially, the label doesn't communicate what it does or when to use it. A misnamed feature is as good as invisible.

Recommendation:

- Rename to *"Notify Guests"* or *"Send Update"*
- Add tooltips explaining its purpose
- Display confirmation: *"Text sent to 5 guests"*

Task 2: Finding 3 - Users Tried to Edit the Event From the Wrong Location

Description: Participants attempted to edit event details,like time change, from the homepage's 3-dot menu, expecting a "quick edit" option. Instead, they had to tap into the event to make changes, which confused them.



Users tried to quickly edit location and time from their home page which only allowed for 3 functions

User Quotes:

"I thought I could just change it here."
"Why isn't there a quick edit?"

Heuristics Violated: **Severity:** 🟡 Medium

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
Feature missing from expected spot	Recognition Rather Than Recall	Users couldn't find the edit option where they expected it
Inconsistent UI behavior	Consistency & Standards	Edit functionality wasn't available in parallel places like homepage and event view

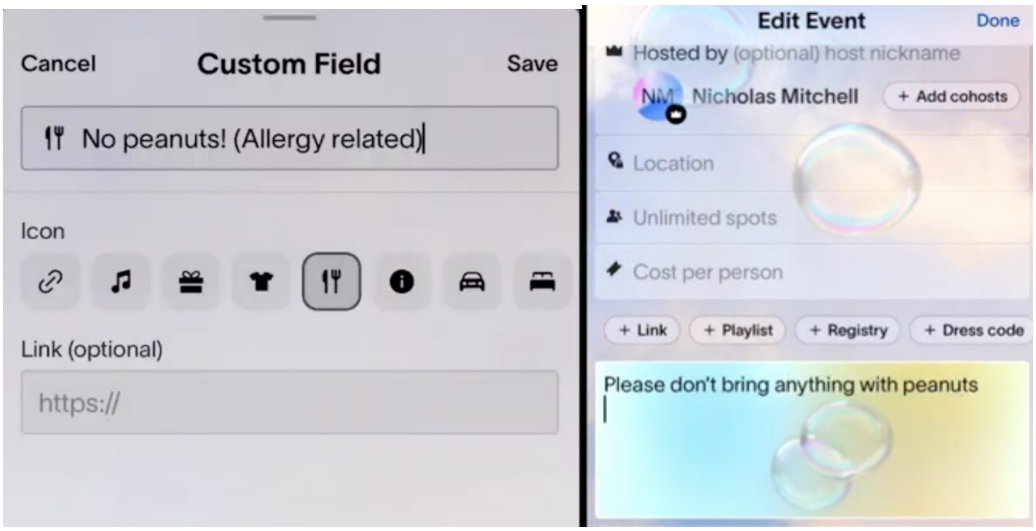
When users try to perform a common action in an intuitive location and fail, it creates friction and breaks flow. In this case, the lack of a quick-edit function forced participants into deeper navigation and undermined their sense of control.
This is especially problematic for repeat hosts who expect speed and efficiency. Poor consistency in where edit actions live can make the product feel incomplete or clunky, even if the functionality exists elsewhere.

Recommendation:

- Enable "quick edit" for key fields(e.g., time change,location change) from homepage menu
- If not feasible, guide users with a tooltip or label
- Ensure consistent icon labels across views

Task 2: Finding 4 - Allergy-Related Info Placed in Event Description Instead of RSVP or Food Section

Description: 2 out of 5 participants entered allergy information in the event description instead of configuring the RSVP questionnaire or using the "+ Food Situation" section. This resulted in allergy notes being buried in the general event description, where guests may not notice them.



Different paths users took to including notes about allergies

User Quotes:
“Should I just put this in the description?”
“I didn’t notice that it was for allergies.”

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🟡 Medium

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
Allergy input flow was unclear	Discoverability	Hosts didn’t find the intended RSVP questionnaire path for dietary info
Misinterpreted “Food Situation” feature	Match Between System & Real World	Labeling didn’t align with expectations for allergy-related setup
Info placed where guests may overlook it	Error Prevention	Allergy info buried in the description risks being missed by guests

Why It Matters:
Hosts entered important allergy or dietary details in the general description because the UI didn’t make it clear how to properly configure guest-facing questions. The “+ Food Situation” label was also misleading, and the RSVP questionnaire feature wasn’t intuitive.

As a result, allergy-related information may not be highlighted to guests, which introduces safety concerns, weakens trust, and forces hosts to rely on workaround behaviors instead of supported flows.

Recommendation:

- Improve onboarding or contextual help to show hosts how to add dietary questions to the RSVP questionnaire

- Clarify labeling of "+ Food Situation" (e.g., *"Event Food Info (e.g., BYOB, Theme)"*)
- Consider adding a labeling "+ Allergy Information"
- Consider adding a dedicated prompt like:
  "Would you like to ask guests about allergies or dietary needs in the RSVP?"

Task 3: Managing Location Changes & Cancellations

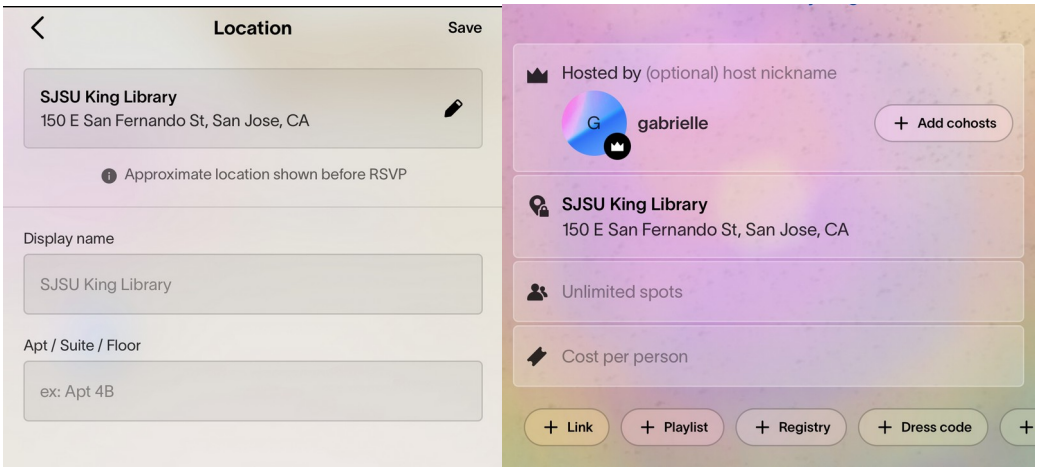
Task Overview:

Participants were asked to modify an existing event by updating the meeting location and then canceling the event. This task evaluated how clearly the system communicates changes, whether users understood how to notify attendees, and if the cancellation process was discoverable, confirmable, and intuitive.

Participant	Task 3: What They Did	Time on Task	Task Completed
P1	Assumed guest notifications happen automatically after cancellation or location change.	2:13.63	Yes
P2	Looked for notification features in the wrong menu	02:10.60	Yes
P3	Didn't get feedback confirming location changes, Used the text blast feature to share the time change.	02:02.86	Yes
P4	Didn't feel confident guests were updated unless they responded.	04:33.19	Yes
P5	Successfully cancelled the event but were confused when it just disappeared.	02:07.87	Yes

Task 3 : Finding 1- Users Assumed Location Changes Automatically Notified Guests

Description:
When changing the event location, participants believed guests would be automatically informed. Some users did not access or recognize the “Text Blast” option after the update and assumed the system had handled it behind the scenes.



Upon clicking save - there is no feedback giving hosts information on if changes will be notified to guests

User Quotes:

“I would expect Partiful to send a text or notification.”
“I didn’t think I had to do anything else.”

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🔴 High

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
No system feedback after edit	Visibility of System Status	Users received no confirmation of guest notifications after updating event details
Assumed automation without options	User Control & Freedom	Lack of user choice or prompts led to false assumptions about system behavior

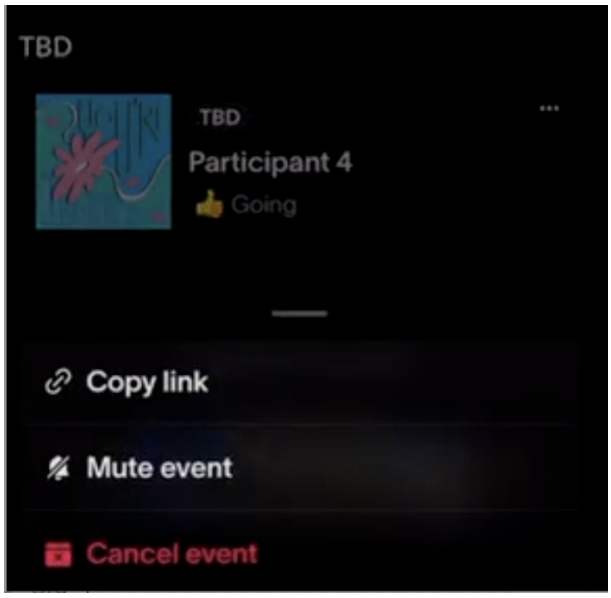
This finding highlights a major trust gap in how Partiful communicates the consequences of user actions. If a host believes guests were notified but they weren’t, it can lead to mismatched arrival locations, missed events, and host embarrassment. At the same time, the absence of any confirmation removes the user’s ability to catch and correct the oversight.

Recommendation:

- After location updates, prompt: *“Would you like to notify your guests of this change?”*
- Show a confirmation banner: *“Update sent to all attendees”* or *“Guests have not yet been notified”*

Task 3: Finding 2 - Users Were Unable to Customize Cancelation of the Event

Description:
After canceling an event, several participants expressed confusion about whether guests were informed. One user expected a visual summary after the cancellation.



Participants were not confident in clicking Cancel Event because of limited feedback

User Quotes:
“I canceled it… but it just disappeared.”
“I wouldn’t know if they saw it unless they told me.”

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🔴 High

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
No feedback on guest notification	Visibility of System Status	Hosts didn’t know if or how guests were notified of cancellation
Lack of confirmation or control	Error Prevention	Users couldn’t verify or amend the action, increasing potential for confusion

Event cancellation is a high-stakes action. If users cancel without feedback or guest notification, it risks guests showing up to a canceled event or simply being confused about what happened. Hosts, in turn, are left second-guessing their actions, or needing to follow up manually.

This moment should include the same care as any core communication feature: clarity, confirmation, and a way to explain changes with empathy. Without those, hosts may distrust the platform or avoid using it for future planning.

Recommendation:

- Provide a post-cancellation summary (e.g., *"Event canceled and guests notified"*)
- Allow a short custom note to be sent with the cancellation
- Use a temporary "undo" option for recent cancellations

Task 4: Messaging & Guest Communication

Task Overview:

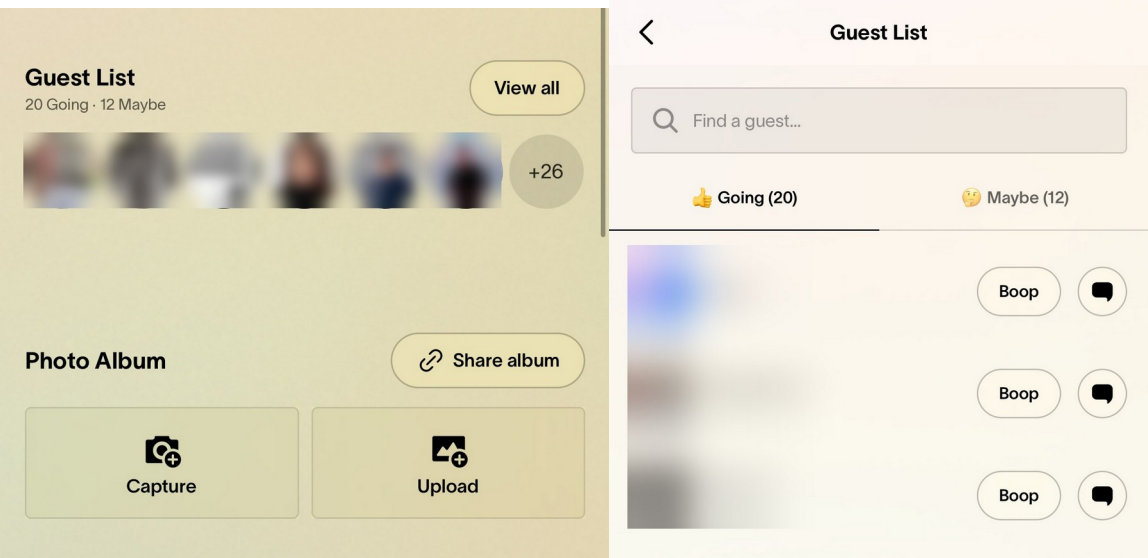
Participants were told they had met someone at a previous event and wanted to reconnect. They were instructed to find that person on Partiful and send them a message. This task evaluated how well the messaging system supported user intent, whether it was discoverable, and how confidently users could complete the interaction.

Participant	Task 4: What They Did	Time on Task	Task Completed
P1	Confused by lack of sent confirmation or unclear red box (error state with no explanation).	01:55.77	No
P2	Didn't know messaging past guests was possible.	00:40.77	Yes
P3	Found the attendee easily and texted them.	01:11.25	Yes
P4	Took multiple clicks to find the "Attended" events section.	02:27.72	Yes
P5	Texted the attendee and hinted that the "boop" feature was pretty useful.	00:47.49	Yes

Task 4: Finding 1 - Users Did Not Realize Messaging Feature Existed

Description:

Most participants only discovered the messaging feature after being prompted or clicking deep into another participant's profile. It was not highlighted in the guest list or on the homepage. The message option lacked visual weight or entry points.



Realization of messaging only comes to light when clicking into guest list

User Quotes:
“Oh… I didn’t know I could do that.”
“I wouldn’t have thought to click on their name.”

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🟡 Medium

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
Messaging not surfaced or visible	Discoverability	If users don’t see a core feature, it might as well not exist
Entry point not clearly labeled	Recognition Rather Than Recall	Users had to remember or stumble upon the feature instead of seeing cues

If users don’t realize they can message other guests, a key social function of the app is missed. This reduces the platform’s stickiness and undermines the promise of post-event connection.

Recommendation:

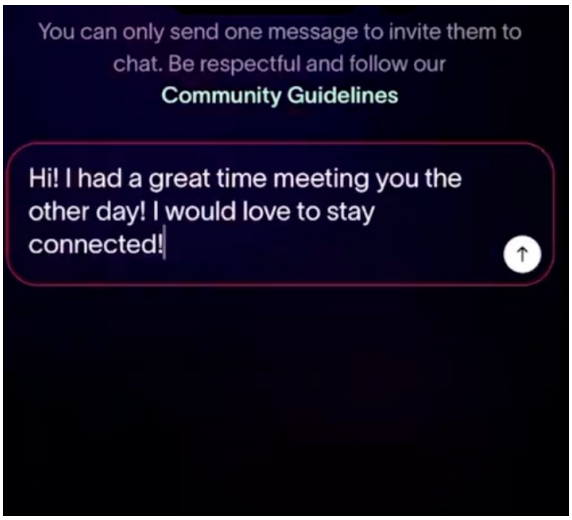
- Highlight messaging capability on guest profiles
- Add a Call to Action, like *“Reconnect with guests”* after an event
- Include a messaging icon in the event guest list
- Allow the option for people to make their profile private if they do not want to use this feature

Task 4: Finding 2 - Users Were Uncertain Whether Messages Were Sent or Delivered

Heuristics Violated: Visibility of System Status, Help Users Recognize & Recover from Errors

Description:

When participants sent messages, the interface did not provide feedback. One participant encountered a red outline around the message box with no explanation. Others waited, clicked again, or assumed it had gone through without confidence.



Red box around messaging - no feedback was given on why & what they were doing wrong

User Quotes:

“It didn’t really say it sent? I think it did?”
“What’s the red box supposed to mean?”

Heuristics Violated: Severity: 🔴 High

Violation	Heuristic Violated	Why It Matters
No success feedback	Visibility of System Status	Users were unsure if their message went through
No help with error states	Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors	Users didn’t know what the red border meant or how to fix it

Messaging often involves reaching out to someone new, or reconnecting after an event. When the system doesn’t confirm a message was sent, or fails to explain errors, users lose trust and may either spam repeat messages or abandon communication entirely. This undermines the app’s social purpose and damages user experience during a vulnerable interaction.

Recommendation:

- Display “Message sent” feedback under the input field
- Add inline error messages when sending fails (e.g., *“Please enter a message before sending”*)
- Replace the red border with a more informative UI pattern

Global Usability Findings

Across all tasks, participants encountered several recurring usability challenges that indicate broader issues with system design, labeling, and user feedback. These global findings represent cross-cutting patterns that go beyond isolated task failures and reflect system-wide breakdowns in visibility, discoverability, and user trust. While individual task findings highlight specific moments of confusion or friction, the following themes emerged repeatedly and have significant implications for both user experience and overall platform reliability.

Global Finding 1: Lack of Clear System Feedback Undermines Trust

Applies to:

- Task 2 (Text Blast, Edit Notification)
- Task 4 (Private Messaging: “Did it send?”)
- Task 1 (RSVP Visibility: “Is this public?”)

Core Problem:

Users frequently completed important actions (like sending messages or updating event details) without receiving any system feedback that confirmed what happened or who was notified. This leads to hesitation, re-checking, or tasks being left incomplete. Users frequently expressed uncertainty about whether their actions (sending a message, canceling an event, editing a time) had actually gone through. The interface often failed

to confirm success, show a “sent” status, or visually reinforce the impact of their choices.

System Impact:
This creates a low-trust environment. When users can’t confirm that their actions were successful, they second-guess themselves, re-check steps, or give up. It increases cognitive load and leads to follow-up texts or manual workarounds that defeat the purpose of the app.

Design Recommendation:
- Add immediate confirmation messages for actions (e.g., *“Text sent to 5 guests”*, *“Your update has been shared”*)
- Add real-time confirmation for key actions (e.g., *“Event canceled and guests notified”*)
- Use visual feedback like color changes, banners, or toast messages
- Show recent changes in a user-visible timeline (e.g., “Updated at 6:42 PM”)
- Reduce latency for features like Text Blast to reinforce responsiveness
- Add gentle prompts for required follow-ups (e.g., “Notify guests?”)

Global Finding 2: Feature Names and Labels Do Not Match User Expectations
Applies to:
- Task 2 (Text Blast)
- Task 4 (Messaging “Red Box”)
- Task 1 (RSVP Comment Box misunderstood)

Core Problem:
Across multiple tasks, users encountered system language that did not match their expectations or mental models. This included ambiguous terms like “Text Blast,” unclear field labels, and features that looked too similar to one another (e.g., RSVP comment vs. host message).

System Impact:
Poorly labeled features increase cognitive load, lead to incorrect use, and reduce confidence in core platform functions, especially when they involve communication.

Design Recommendation:
- Rename “Text Blast” to something more descriptive (e.g., *“Notify Guests”*)
- Add tooltips or onboarding tips for lesser-known features

- Clarify labels with examples or visibility cues (e.g., *“public comment,” “visible to host only”*)

Global Finding 3: Unclear Boundaries Between Public and Private Information

Applies to:

- Task 1 (RSVP Comment Box)
- Task 2 (Event Creation – Dietary Field)
- Task 4 (Messaging “Red Box”)

Core Problem:

Across multiple tasks, participants struggled to determine which information would be visible to guests, hosts, or just themselves. In Task 1, guests mistakenly posted sensitive dietary info in a public comment box, assuming it was private. In Task 2, hosts typed allergy details into the event description, unsure if guests would see it. In Task 4, users were confused about whether their private messages had been sent — or who could read them.

System Impact:

This breakdown in visibility and privacy cues led to hesitation, mistrust, and unintended oversharing. When users can’t clearly distinguish public from private input fields, they lose confidence in the system and may withhold critical information — or share more than they intend. This is especially risky in contexts involving allergies, logistics, or personal messages.

Design Recommendation:

- Add clear, inline labels to all user-facing fields (e.g., *“Visible to all guests”*, *“Host only”*)
- Use preview states or confirmation banners that show what others will see
- Provide a visual distinction between guest-facing vs. host-only messages
- Highlight allergy-related content with icons and alert styling to draw attention

Global Finding 4: Discoverability of Critical Inputs Is Weak

Applies to:

- Task 1 (Dietary Preferences – RSVP)
- Task 2 (Food Situations – Event Creation)
- Task 4 (Messaging Feature)

Core Problem:

Across the study, participants frequently missed or misunderstood key inputs and features because they were poorly placed, labeled ambiguously, or hidden behind subtle interface elements. Users didn't realize where or how to enter dietary info, how to add food alerts as a host, or how to message a past guest.

System Impact:

When users can't discover or recognize core functionality, they resort to workarounds (e.g., typing allergies into the wrong field), abandon tasks, or assume the platform lacks features it actually has. This damages usability and can increase safety risks, especially around dietary needs.

Design Recommendation:

- Elevate critical fields like dietary restrictions higher in the user flow
- Use clearer labels and icons (e.g., 🍽 “Add Dietary Restrictions”)
- Highlight messaging capabilities earlier in the guest journey
- Introduce progressive disclosure (e.g., nudges or guided tips when editing events)

Conclusion

Discussion

This usability evaluation of Partiful revealed several critical usability issues that impact both guest and host experiences across the platform. Participants frequently encountered confusion around privacy boundaries, system feedback, and the discoverability of essential features such as messaging, dietary fields, and guest notifications. While users were generally able to complete core tasks, their behavior indicated hesitation, workarounds, and uncertainty that point to deeper design misalignments with user mental models.

These issues were not limited to single-use cases but emerged consistently across tasks, suggesting that Partiful's current design does not fully support its goals of ease, clarity, and socially-driven event planning. In particular, the platform lacks sufficient feedback mechanisms to confirm actions, and uses ambiguous or non-standard labels that hinder comprehension. Left unaddressed, these gaps could reduce user trust, lead to miscommunication, and prevent users from adopting or continuing to use the product confidently.

To better understand where these breakdowns occurred and how they relate to established usability principles, we analyzed each finding through the lens of Nielsen's heuristics. The following scorecard summarizes which usability principles were violated and how frequently, across all observed tasks.

Heuristic Violation Scorecard

Heuristic Principle	Task 1	Task 2	Task 3	Task 4	Total Violations
🔴 **Visibility of System Status**	🔴 2	🔴 2	🔴 1	🔴 1	**6**
🟡 **Match Between System & Real World**	🔴 1	🟡 1	–	🟡 1	**3**
🟡 **Recognition Rather Than Recall**	🟡 1	🟡 2	–	🔴 1	**4**

🟡 **Discoverability / Hidden Affordance**	🔴 1	🟡 2	–	🟡 1	**4**
🟡 **Consistency & Standards**	–	🔴 2	–	🔴 1	**3**

Top 3 Violations:

1. 🔴 Visibility of System Status (6 violations)

Most frequently violated heuristic across all tasks.
Participants were repeatedly left uncertain about whether actions (e.g., sending messages, updating events, RSVP submission) were completed successfully due to a lack of visual or system feedback.
Implication: Undermines user trust and increases likelihood of errors or manual workarounds.
Tasks Impacted: Task 1, Task 2, Task 3, Task 4

2. 🟡 Recognition Rather Than Recall (4 violations)

Participants struggled to remember where features or actions were located.
Features like editing events or sending messages were not easily discoverable or consistently placed, requiring users to search or guess.
Implication: Increased cognitive load and slowed task flow.
Tasks Impacted: Task 1, Task 2, Task 4

3. 🟡 Discoverability / Hidden Affordance (4 violations)

Important fields (like dietary restrictions or messaging) were hidden or poorly labeled.
Participants either missed key inputs or didn't realize what they were for.
Implication: Critical functionality (especially around guest communication and allergies) went unused or was misused.
Tasks Impacted: Task 1, Task 2, Task 4

Partiful Usability Scorecard

This scorecard summarizes participant experience across four core usability dimensions: learnability, discoverability, feedback clarity, and trust in information visibility. Each rating reflects a synthesis of behavioral observations, task completion trends, and participant feedback.

Usability Question	Grade	Explanation

🧭 *Is the platform easy to learn and use on the first try?*	**B-**	While visually playful, unclear form structure and RSVP flow challenged first-time users.
🔎 *Are core features discoverable and accessible?*	**D+**	Participants struggled to locate key features like “Text Blast” and guest messaging due to poor labeling and navigation cues.
💬 *Does the system provide helpful feedback and confirmations?*	**D**	No clear confirmation for messages or updates left users uncertain and repeatedly second-guessing their actions.
🧠 *Does the interface clearly distinguish public vs. private actions?*	**C-**	Multiple users misunderstood who could see comments or profile info, leading to trust and privacy concerns.
⭐ ***Overall Usability Grade***	**C-**	**Despite a fun, social tone, major gaps in system visibility, trust, and discoverability reduce the platform’s effectiveness.**

Contact Information

Project Team + Research Lead Info

We’re excited to see where this goes! If you have any questions or need more information, please feel free to reach out to our research team:

Vipashyana Patel

Nicholas Mitchell

Gabrielle Orzech

Liz Almonte

Jackson Burke

Appendix

Study Execution Checklist

Pre-Session Setup (Lab & Equipment)

□ Verify overhead and spot lighting are functional and provide sufficient visibility for recordings
☐ Launch Partiful site on testing device (browser or app), logged out or pre-set to scenario state
☐ Ensure all other apps, tabs, or notifications are closed or disabled
☐ Confirm WiFi connection is stable and speed sufficient for live demos and recordings
☐ Position and test all camera angles:
    ☐ Frontal view of participant
    ☐ Screen view
    ☐ Side view for body language
    ☐ Wide room view (if applicable)
☐ AV Technician verifies all four video feeds are recording and streaming to observation room
☐ Data Logger preps observational log sheet or digital template
☐ Consent forms and pens laid out at reception

Participant Check-In

□ Greet participant, confirm scheduled session and ID
☐ Share printed Informed Consent Form and Confidentiality Agreement
☐ Allow participant time to review and sign documents
☐ Escort participant to waiting area; offer water/snacks if applicable
☐ Confirm demographic screener sheet is filled (if not done online)

During the Session

☐ Escort participant into the testing room
☐ Moderator reads standard script and confirms participant understanding
☐ Start screen and camera recording
☐ Begin predefined task scenarios (e.g., RSVP, create event, cancel, edit details)
☐ Use checklist to ensure all core tasks are completed based on participant background
☐ Deploy scenario-specific probes at relevant moments
☐ Observe and log:
    ☐ Time on task
    ☐ Errors or requests for help
    ☐ Verbalizations of confusion
    ☐ Non-verbal behaviors (e.g., hesitations, sighs, looking around)

Post-Session Wrap-Up

☐ Ask post-task interview questions per script
☐ Optional: Confirm if participant is open to future follow-up (for longitudinal studies)
☐ Escort participant back to reception
☐ Deliver $100 cash incentive and thank them
☐ Mark participant session as complete in tracking sheet

Post-Session Reset

☐ Save and label all session recordings using participant ID
☐ Backup AV files to secure cloud drive or external storage
☐ Sanitize workstation, keyboard, and mouse
☐ Reset browser/app to neutral state for next session
☐ Refresh water/snacks, reprint materials if low
☐ AV Technician verifies readiness for next session

Recruitment Flyer



Recruitment Email

Subject: Participants Needed for App Usability Study – $100 Compensation

Dear **[Recipient's Name],**

I'm reaching out to invite you to participate in a research study evaluating a new event-planning app called Partiful. This usability study is being conducted by Lumon Research in downtown San Jose.

Study Highlights:

- **Study Title:** Usability Evaluation of the Partiful Event Planning App
- **Hosted By:** Lumon Research, Human Factors Researchers
- **Time:** 1 session (70 minutes)
- **Location:** 500 N Santa Clara St & First St, San Jose, CA
- **Compensation:** $100 cash
- **Eligibility:** Ages 18–35 and fluent in English

We're especially interested in individuals who are planning to host an event soon, but no prior experience with Partiful is required!

A flyer with more details is attached. If you're interested or have any questions, feel free to reply directly to this email or visit **LumonResearch.com/Partiful** to sign up.

Thank you for your time. We'd love to have you be part of this research!

Warm regards,
[Your Name]
Lumon Research
[Your Contact Email]

Consent Form

CONSENT FORM - REQUEST FOR YOUR PARTICIPATION IN RESEARCH

TITLE OF THE STUDY

Evaluating Usability and User Perception of the Partiful Event Planning App

RESEARCHERS

Principal Investigator: Gabrielle Orzech

PURPOSE

This study explores how users interact with Partiful, a digital event planning and invitation platform. The goal is to evaluate the app's usability from both the event host and event guest perspectives. The research focuses on how users create, customize, and manage events, as well as how they RSVP, interact socially, and engage with shared media and notifications. Insights from this study will inform improvements to user experience and system design.

PROCEDURES

This study will be conducted in the User Research Lab at 500 N Santa Clara Street & First Street, San Jose, CA. Each session will last approximately 45–60 minutes.

During the session, you will be asked to complete a series of realistic tasks such as:

- Creating or managing an event (as a host)
- RSVPing and interacting with an event invite (as a guest)
- Exploring social features (e.g., commenting, uploading photos)
- Editing event details or canceling an event
- Navigating guest lists and system-generated reminders

After each task, we will conduct a short interview with you to gather your thoughts about the interface and user experience. This interview may be audio recorded to help the research team accurately capture your feedback. While your name will not be saved

with the recording, your voice may be considered identifying information. The recordings will only be used for research purposes, stored securely, and deleted after transcription and project completion. You may choose to not have the audio be recorded and still fully participate in the study.

With your permission, photographs may be taken during the study to document the experimental setup and interactions with the UI. These images may include visible features such as your hands, arms, or face, depending on the angle needed for documentation. Photos will be used only for research records, study design reference, or academic presentations. They will not be shared publicly without additional consent. You may choose to decline photography or request your face not to be included and still fully participate in the study.

POTENTIAL RISKS

Risks are minimal and similar to everyday mobile app use. You may experience temporary frustration with unclear features or minor discomfort if your behavior is observed or recorded. You are free to skip any task or question and may stop the session at any time without penalty

If for any reason at any time during the study, you experience any type of discomfort or feel you are no longer able to proceed with the study, you have the right to end the experiment, even after signing this consent form.

POTENTIAL BENEFITS

While there is no direct personal benefit, your feedback will help improve Partiful and inform future user-centered design decisions. You will be contributing to research in Human Factors and usability testing.

COMPENSATION

You will receive $100 in cash after completing the session.

CONFIDENTIALITY

Personally identifiable data will only be collected from informed consent forms, initial screening(including email communication and screening surveys), and where applicable, audio recordings of usability interviews. These audio recordings will be processed by the research team to remove any personally identifiable details (e.g., participant names). Consent forms, which cannot be de-identified, will be stored on an encrypted drive placed in our company's secure Google Drive accessible only to the research team. These forms will be kept for 3 years after study completion before being securely destroyed.

Other identifying information (e.g., data linking you to your assigned ID numbers) will be stored separately from performance and usability data. Data collected during tasks (accuracy, response time) and usability feedback (e.g., surveys and interviews) will be labeled only by randomly assigned participant ID numbers to maintain anonymity.

All data, including processed audio recordings, questionnaires, and performance metrics, will be stored on an encrypted drive hosted by the institution and accessible exclusively to the research team. Data will be securely stored for 3 years following the completion of the study and then permanently deleted.

PARTICIPANT RIGHTS

Your participation in this study is completely voluntary. You can refuse to participate in the entire study or any part of the study without any negative effect on your relations with San Jose State University. You also have the right to skip any question you do not wish to answer. This consent form is not a contract. It is a written explanation of what will happen during the study if you decide to participate. You will not waive any rights if you choose not to participate, and there is no penalty for stopping your participation in the study.

QUESTIONS OR PROBLEMS

If you have any questions about this study, please contact:

- For further information about the study, please contact the principal investigator, Gabrielle Orzech.

SIGNATURES

Your signature below indicates that you voluntarily agree to participate in this study, that the details of the study have been explained to you, and that your questions have been answered. You will receive a copy of this consent form for your records.

If you agree to audio recording for feedback purposes, please indicate your preference:

- I agree to be audio recorded: YES NO
- I agree to photos of my hands, wrist, arms, neck: YES NO
- I agree to photos of my face: YES NO

Participant Signature: Date:

Participant Name (printed):

Researcher Statement

I certify that the participant has been given adequate time to learn about the study and ask questions. It is my opinion that the participant understands his/her rights and the

purpose, risks, benefits, and procedures of the research and has voluntarily agreed to participate.

Researcher Signature: Date:

Screener Questionnaire

Screener Questionnaire

Study Title: Evaluating Usability and User Perception of the Partiful Event Planning App

Investigator: Principal Investigator: Gabrielle Orzech

Purpose: This form will be used to determine whether you are eligible to participate in this research study

1. Are you between the ages of 18 and 25?
    - Yes
    - No
2. Are you fluent in English?
    - Yes
    - No
3. Have you ever used the Partiful app or website before?
    - Yes
    - No
        i. If Yes, how many times have you used Partiful?
        _____
        ii. If yes, in what way(s) have you used Partiful?
        _____
        _____
        _____
        _____

_____
_____

4. Have you ever been diagnosed with a cognitive disorder that may impact memory, attention, or language processing?
    - Yes
    - No
5. Preferred Contact Method for Study Participation:
    - Name:
    - Email:
    - Phone(optional):

Study Walk Through

This sample reflects how we logged participant behavior, time on task, observed usability issues, and follow-up interview responses for a single task. It also shows how we tracked heuristic violations, participant confusion, and verbal feedback to inform findings.

Task 1: First-Time Guest – RSVP & Privacy Exploration

Simulated Invite Link:

The participant will be sent a test event invite via text message. We observed how they interpreted the invite, whether they click, RSVP, or create a profile. The goal of this scenario was to explore trust, onboarding clarity, and perceived legitimacy. This task allowed us to assess the discoverability of the product onboarding from the perspective of a new user.

Observations were noted by the data logger and the observer, while the moderator guided the participant when he requested for help or clarification.

Moderator: "*Open the link Alex sent via text."*

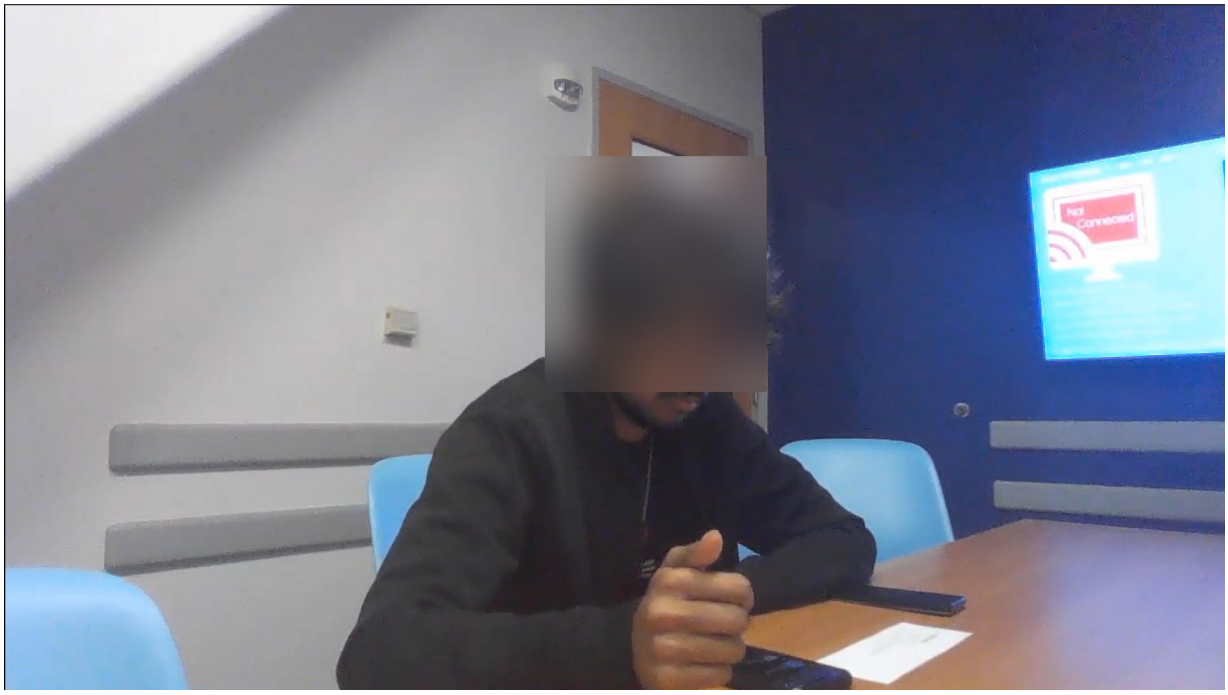


Fig: Attempting to open the link from the text message they just received

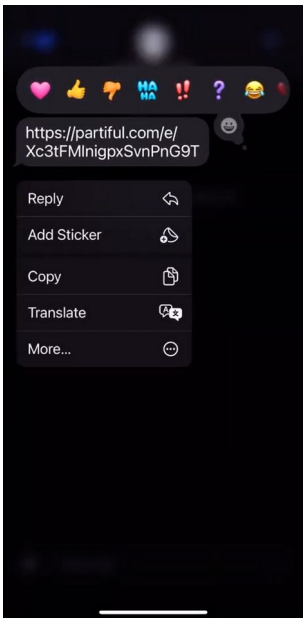


Fig: Participant copying the link from text which redirects them to the browser instead of the application

(Error)

Observations

	Metrics	Participant 3
Performance	Time on Task	1:27.81
	Task Error	Commented the vegetarian diet in the comment box which is shared to every attendee in the party
	Task abandonment	N/A
	Task Completion Success	Yes
Behavioral		The participant performed the task with confidence. However he asked for clarification on noting the vegetarian preference. The participant also displayed confusion when probed for personal information being shared.
Subjective (Verbal)	Unprompted talk aloud (If natural)	“I see an invite to something that is hosted by Liz” “Um location has not been set.”
	Indicating ease of use	“Pretty easy to use”
	Asked for help/Clarification	“Uh Is there something for me to note?” “Um I cannot see anybody else’s information.”
	Satisfaction Rating	“It was easy to figure”

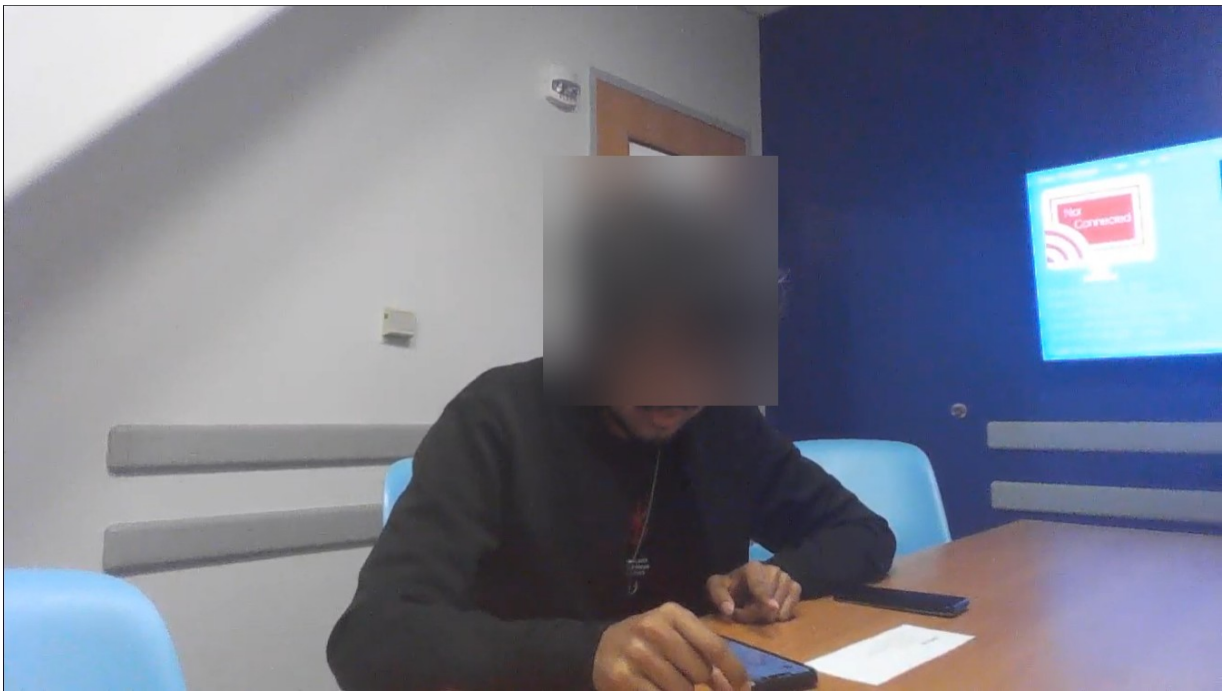


Fig: Participant 3 scrolls back when moderator asks to note the date and time of the event

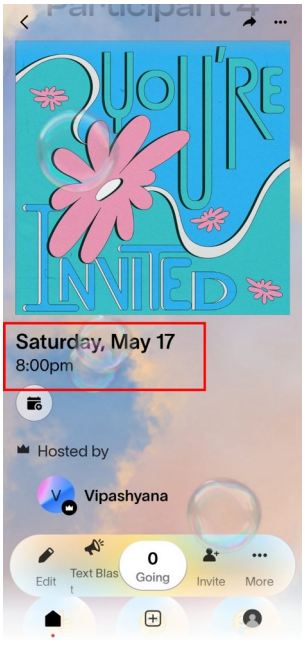


Fig: Participant 3 scrolls back when moderator asks to note the date and time of the event

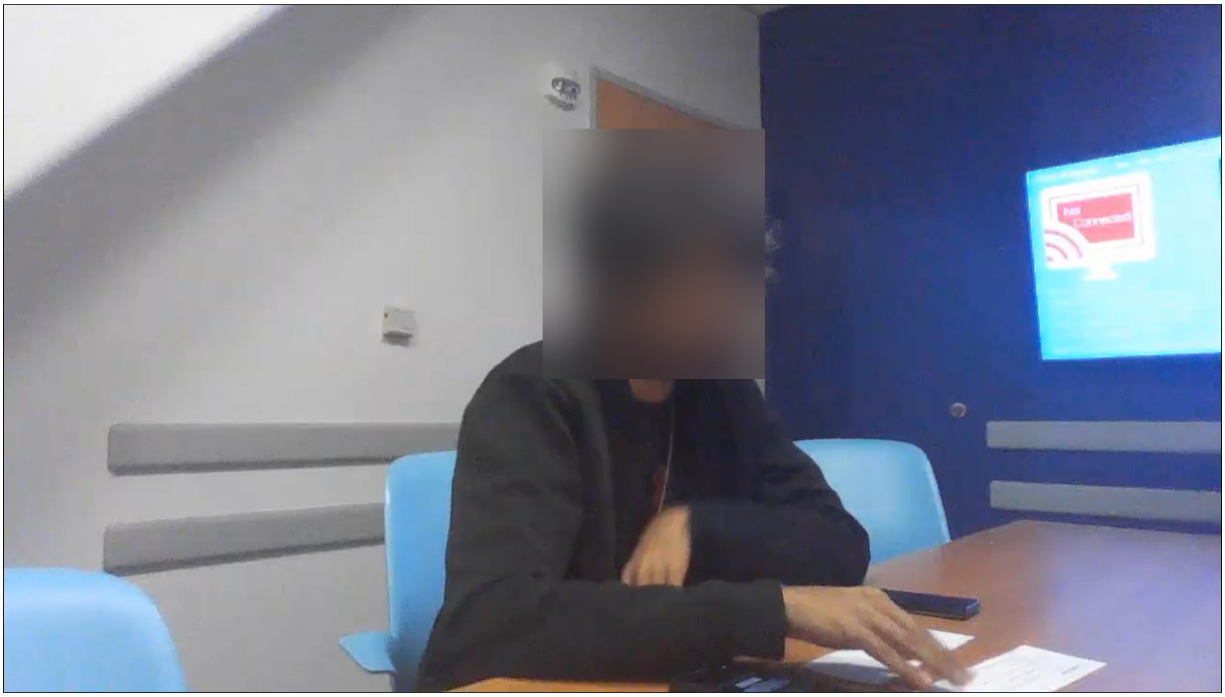


Fig: Participant 3 reading the prompt again when prompted to add the dietary restriction when he could not find the dietary preference selection in the invite (Behavioral: looks for help)



Fig: Participant 3 asking for help in adding the dietary preferences “Uh Is there something for me to note?” (Follow up questions)

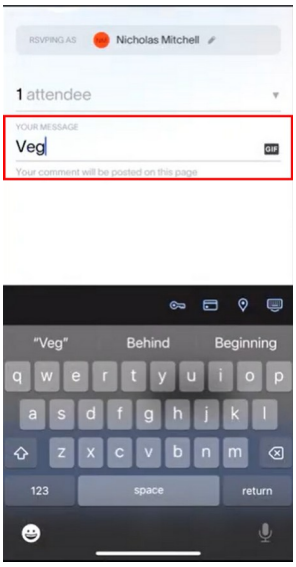


Fig: Participant entering the dietary preferences in the comment box (Error)

Observations (Participant performing Task 1)

	Behavioral	Subjective
Asked for help	No	
Displayed Confusion	Yes	“Uh Is there something for me to note?” “Um I cannot see anybody else’s information.”

Observations (Knowledge-Based Probes)

	Behavioral	Subjective
What do you think happens after you RSVP?	Scrolls through the invitation	“It shows me an update of my RSVP”
What personal information do you expect others can see about you?	Goes back on the main page (from the event page) Clicks on the event again	“Um I cannot see anybody else’s information” “I don’t think my information is shared” “Other than my preference, I don’t know if they’ll be able to see anything else, because, I I I don’t know if if the activity is, I don’t know if it can be seen by others.”
Would you feel safe and comfortable responding to invitations this way regularly?	Nods in agreement	“Yep”

Observations (Post-Task Interview)

	Behavioral	Subjective

Did the app make it clear how your information would be shared?		“Um I do not know if that will be shared to the others in the guest list, because i am the only guest, but to the host, i can see how it shares my information.” “Um I cannot see anybody else’s information” “I don’t think my information is shared” “Other than my preference, I don’t know if they’ll be able to see anything else, because, I I I don’t know if if the activity is, I don’t know if it can be seen by others.”
Were there any points of confusion or concern regarding your privacy?	Scrolls, nods in disagreement	“No”

Findings:

	Expectation	Reality
Participant commented while sharing the dietary information	Dietary question should have been a question and easily discoverable. This would be visible to hosts only.	The participant misunderstood the comment box and added the dietary restrictions in the comment box. The comment is now publicly shared

Recommendations:

Principles violated	Usability issue	Recommendation
Hidden Affordance Discoverability	Although the application has a feature for dietary restriction, it was not easily discoverable	Clearly show an option for dietary preference

Match Between system and real world	The application does not guide the user easily to the right input	Change the placeholder text from comment to something that aligns better with user mental model
Error Prevention	No prompt to prevent errors	Inform users that the comment will be shared to everyone who will be attending the party

Task 2: First-Time Host – Creating and Adjusting an Event

First Time Event Creation:
A participant is asked to create an event for a dinner party. They are told to personalize the theme, set a time, and invite 3 friends.
Goals: Evaluate ease of event creation, discoverability of customization options, and mental model alignment for first-time hosts

Observations were noted by the data logger and the observer, while the moderator guided the participant when he requested for help or clarification.

Moderator: *"Create your event on Partiful and choose a theme that matches your casual gathering."*

Observations

	Metrics	Participant 3
Performance	Time on Task	04:52.19
	Task Error	● Two misclicks before editing the event ● Could not inform the attendees about the time change initially, assuming that they would've received it.
	Task abandonment	N/A
	Task Completion Success	Yes
Behavioral		The participant performed the task successfully with a few clarifications. However, he was confused with editing the event. He did not ask for help on any tasks.

Subjective (Verbal)	Unprompted talk aloud (If natural)	“That is today which is friday” “Spots” “I think I have all the information in my event” “Done”
	Indicating ease of use	
	Asked for help/clarification	“Should I mention the Peanut allergy?”
	Satisfaction Rating	



Fig: Participant 3 reading the prompt again before editing the event (Behavioral: looks for help)

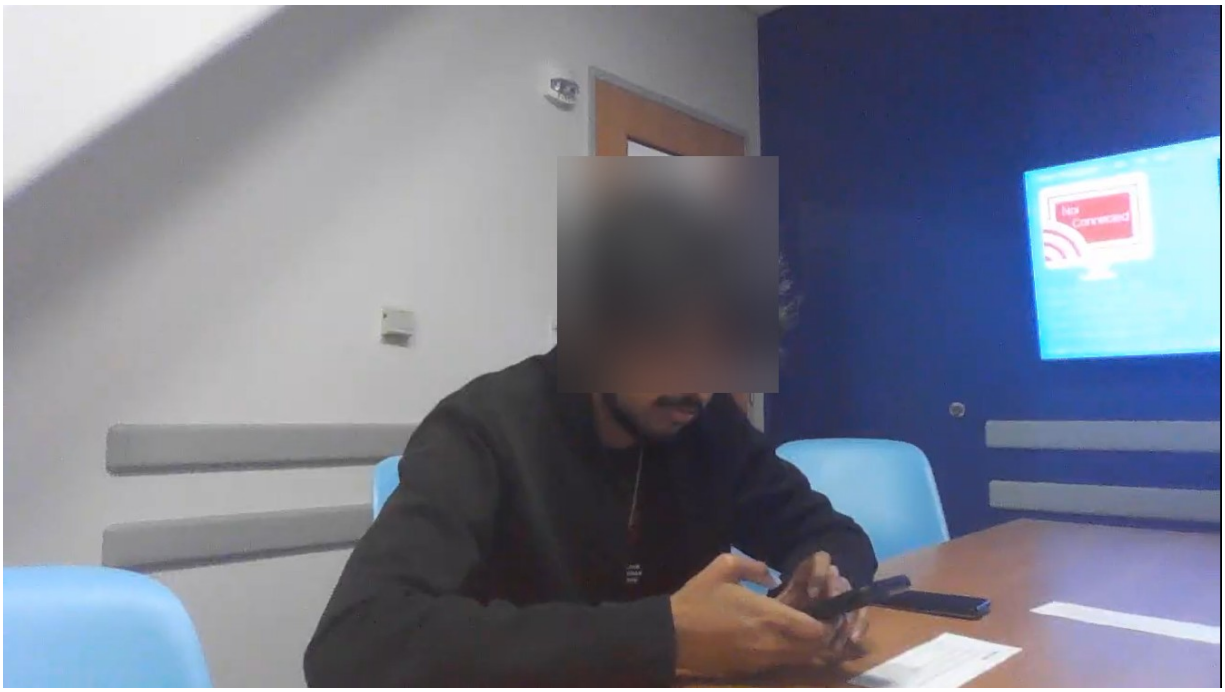


Fig: Participant 3 confused with edit event, two misclicks and finally figures out (Follow up questions)

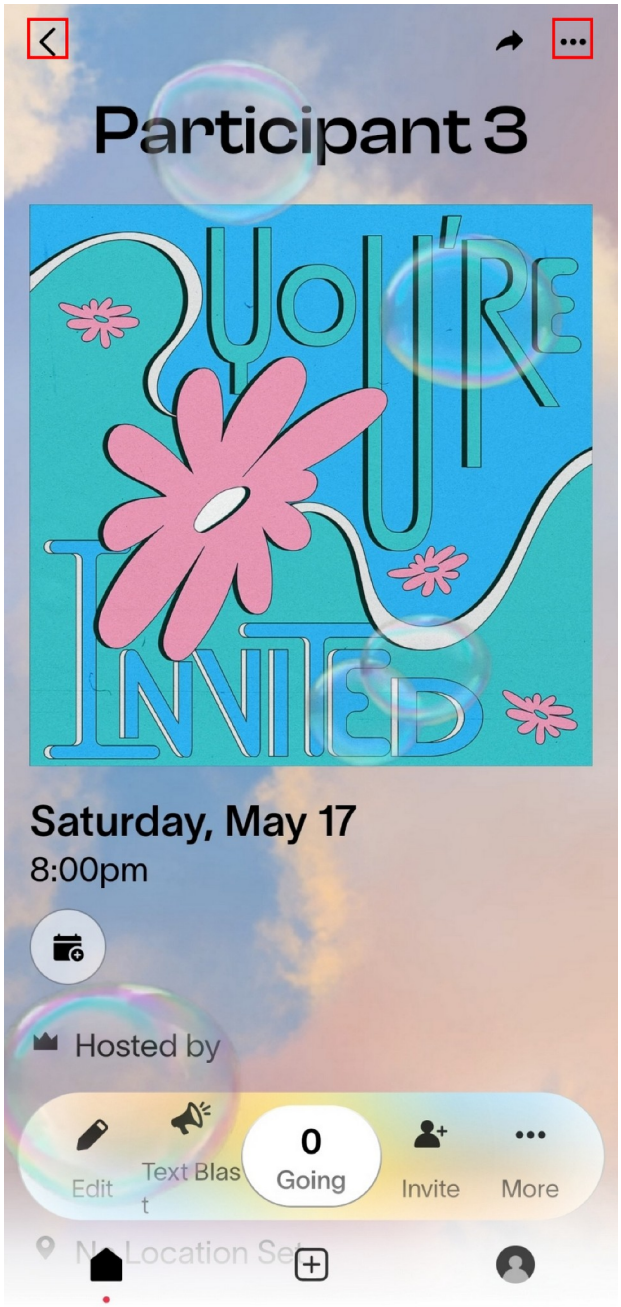


Fig: Participant 3 clicks on the wrong menu

Observations (Participant performing Task 2)

	Behavioral	Subjective

Asked for help/clarification	Yes Occasional pauses Glances to and fro over the prompt paper	“What is the event for?”
Displayed Confusion	Yes	

Observations (Knowledge-Based Probes)

	Behavioral	Subjective
How clearly do you think your guests will understand the peanut allergy restriction?	Brief Pause, Scrolls through the event	That is the only content that i have added in my description so should be able to get that message
How do you anticipate your guests will be aware of the updated start time? Here is where we mention the truth if they missed it. This lets us inquire WHY they missed it, what they expected (what was expected from updating? Lack of a button for it?)		“Done” “Um i don’t see anything that tells me that they were notified” “I think once i make the change o um my invite, if I receive *a prompt to send that to my guests that would be a clear way of doing it.”*
NOW Inquire about Text Blast: Did you see it? What did you think it was *supposed* to be (What would you think it was if we hadn't asked?) Did you see the navigation bar? Possibly inquire why they think that is. (participant usually blames self here, but might be worth asking depending on the person). What do you think it WILL do if you used it? (without	Nods in agreement	“I can see it” “Can i try using it?” “Is this, can i send text blasts whenever i want to the guests that I have invited” “This is a nice way of notifying any changes”

tapping on it.) Then let them tap on it, see what was different from their mental model.		

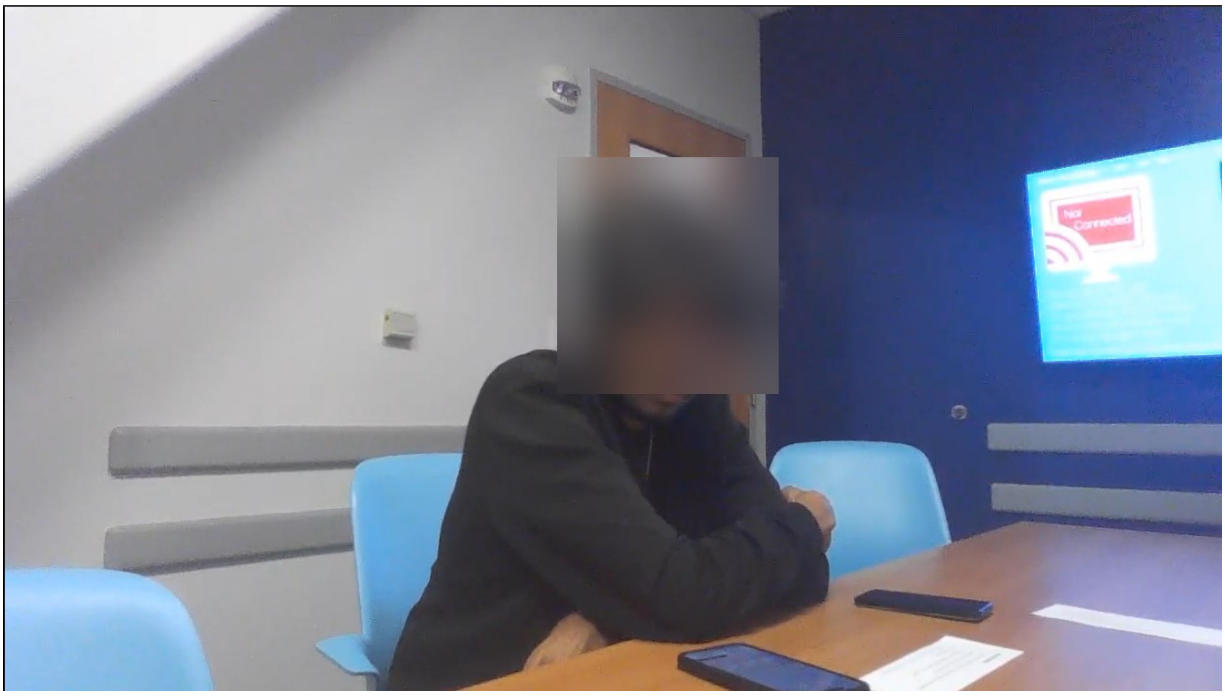


Fig: Participant 3 nods in disagreement when probed about was he aware of the text blast feature

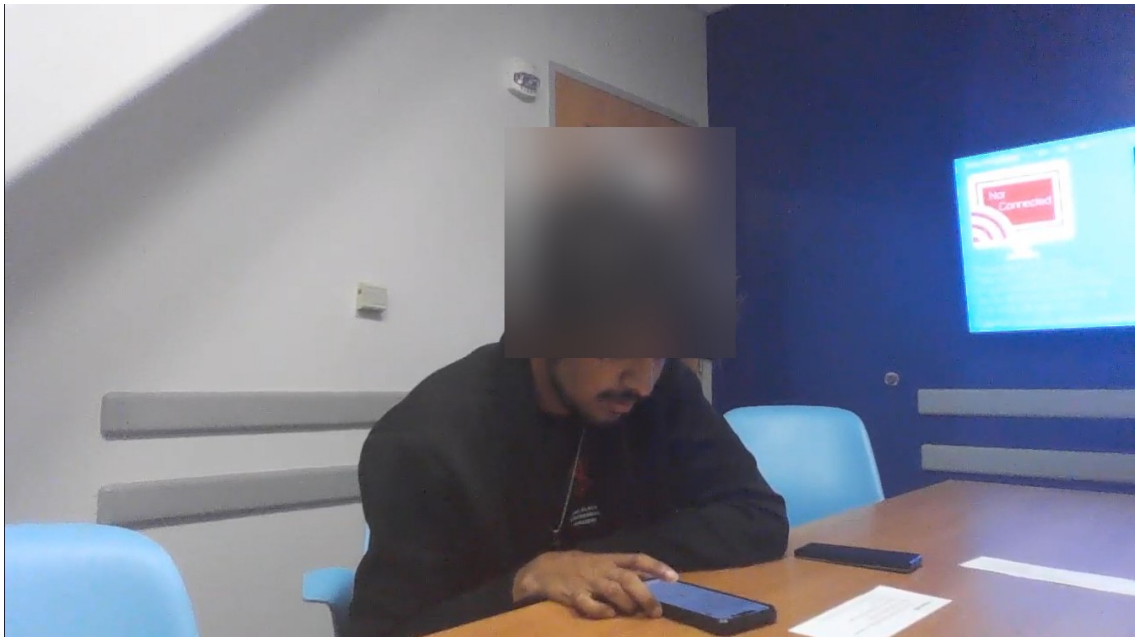


Fig: Participant 3 trying the text blast feature (Free Play)

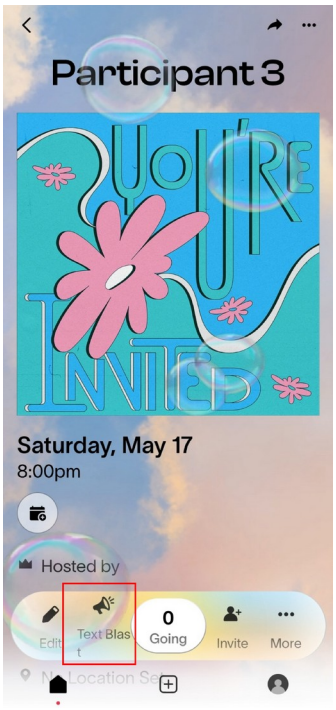


Fig: Participant trying the text blast feature (Free Play)

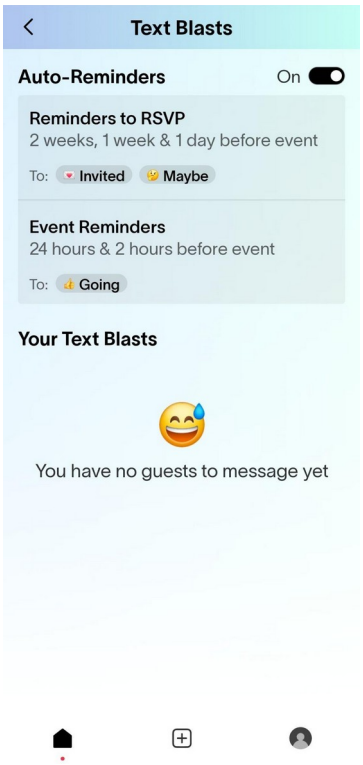


Fig: Participant trying the text blast feature (Free Play)

Observations (Post-Task Interview)

	Behavioral	Subjective
Did you *initially* feel confident that guests received notifications about changes?	Nods in disagreement	“No.” “I think just by making a change to the event they shouldn’t receive a notification because we might not have made the right change/” “I want it to be reliable (text blast).”

Was customizing the event and communicating restrictions straightforward?	Scrolls, nods in agreement	“Yes”
What would you expect from a feature like this? What would you want in a feature like this?	Brief pause	“I would expect it to be reliable.”

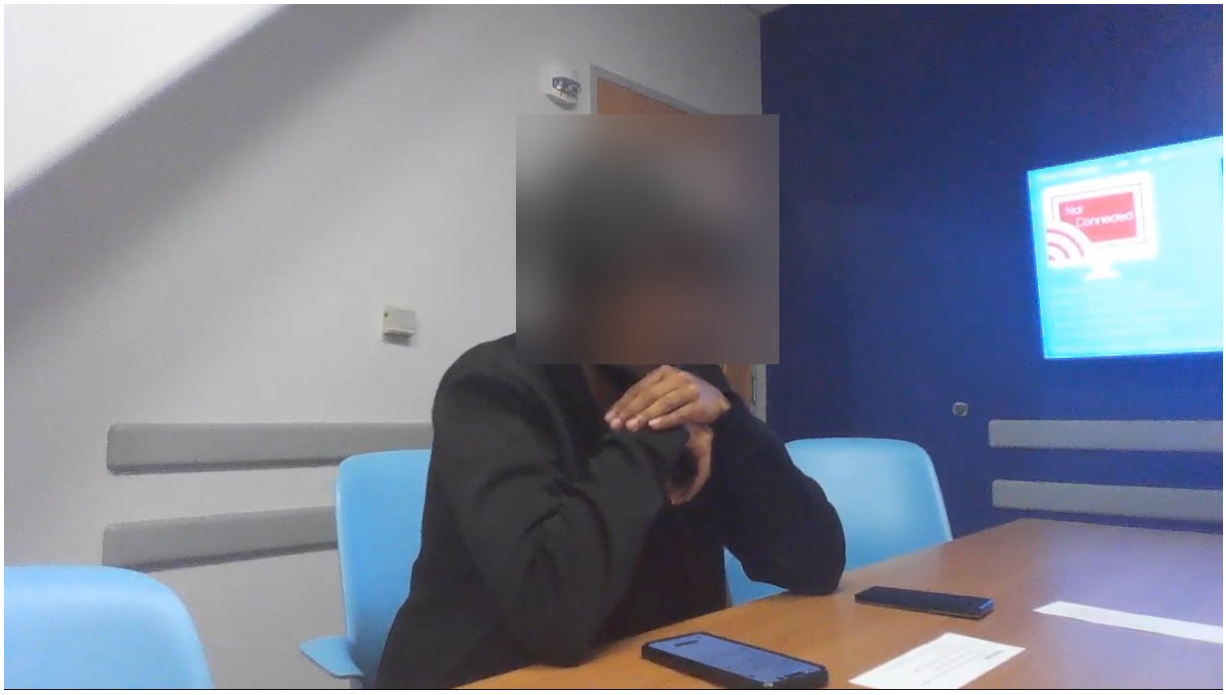


Fig: Participant 3 sharing how he expects the notification to go out

Findings:

	Expectation	Reality
Participant did not realize the guests were notified about the time change	When changing the time, participant expected a confirmation to whether they wanted to send out the change or not	The participant hoped that changing the time would've sent the update. When probed, he responded "I think just by making a change to the event they shouldn't receive a notification because we might not have made the right change."
Wrong taps to find the edit event button	Editing event time should be straightforward	Participant tapped on the information menu instead of edit button in the event
Wrong fiend to share the peanut allergy	Participant should've chosen food situation to write about the peanut (a specific feature)	Participant commented the peanut allergy in description

Recommendations:

Principles violated	Usability issue	Recommendation
Visibility of system status	The participant was not notified of the update	Push notification confirming the update
User Control and Freedom	No control over whether they want to update the event	Prompt the user whether they want to make a change to the event or not
Hidden affordance	Participant does not know the function of the text blast feature	Describe how they could use the text blast feature using a tool tip if they are a new user. Or motion to draw attention.

Task 3: Experienced Host – Managing Venue Changes & Cancellations

Event Cancellation After RSVPS:
The participant is asked to cancel an event after others have RSVP'd

Goal: Explore user awareness of how cancellation affects guests, and whether the interface communicates this clearly.

Observations were noted by the data logger and the observer, while the moderator guided the participant when he requested for help or clarification.

Moderator: “Navigate to your existing hiking event and update the meeting location to the picnic shelter.”

Observations

	Metrics	Participant 3
Performance	Time on Task	02:02.86
	Task Error	N/A
	Task abandonment	N/A
	Task Completion Success	Yes
Behavioral		The participant performed the task with confidence.
Subjective (Verbal)	Unprompted talk aloud (If natural)	“Updated the event.” “Cancelled due to bad weather.” “Notify - Text Blast”
	Indicating ease of use	“I am confident”
	Asked for help/clarification	N/A
	Satisfaction Rating	“It was easy to figure”

Observations (Participant performing Task 3)

	Behavioral
Asked for help	No
Displayed Confusion	No

Observations (Knowledge-Based Probes)

	Subjective
After updating the event location, how confident are you that guests will be aware of the change?	“Very confident.”
Upon cancellation, how clear do you expect the communication to be about the cancellation?	“I am confident about that also, because it is sending notifications”

Observations (Post-Task Interview)

	Behavioral	Subjective
Did you feel assured that your guests were promptly notified about these event changes?	N/A	“Yes.”
Did the app adequately convey the impact and visibility of your event updates and cancellations?	Scrolls, nods in agreement	“Hmm hmm”
Did any aspect of managing event changes or cancellations feel confusing or challenging from a usability or communication perspective?	N/A	“All clear”

Findings:

	Expectation	Reality
Participant successfully notified the location change	Participant will use the text blast feature to notify	Participant used the feature as expected

	attendees	
Participant did not receive feedback on updated location	Location updated feedback should be sent to the participant too	Participant updated the location and notified attendees via text blast

Task 4: Reconnecting with a New Friend from a Past Event

Reconnecting with someone the participant met:
The participant is told they met someone at a previous party and they hit it off with them. They would like to reconnect with that person, and do not have their contact information.

Goal: Observe user understanding of this feature, and connect through the application.

Moderator: “Open Partiful and try to connect with Vipashyana.”

Observations

	Metrics	Participant 3
Performance	Time on Task	01:11.25
	Task Error	N/A
	Task abandonment	N/A
	Task Completion Success	Yes
Behavioral		The participant performed the task with confidence.
Subjective (Verbal)	Unprompted talk aloud (If natural)	N/A
	Indicating ease of use	N/A
	Asked for help/clarification	N/A
	Satisfaction Rating	N/A

Observations (Participant performing Task 4)

	Behavioral
Asked for help	No
Displayed Confusion	No

Observations (Knowledge-Based Probes)

	Subjective
How confident are you that this person will receive your message?	“Confident.”
What do you think happens when you send a message through Partiful?	“The person must’ve received it.”
Was it clear who you’re allowed to message or view from past events?	“Yes”

Observations (Post-Task Interview)

	Subjective
Was it easy or difficult to find someone from a past event?	“Very easy.”
Did the process feel natural or awkward in	“Pretty natural”

any way?	
Did you have any concerns about whether they would receive the message or how they'd perceive it?	"No"
Where did you expect those features to be, and how did that compare to where they were?	"They were pretty much where I expected them to be."
Would you be likely to use this feature again after an event?	"Yes, I will."

Findings:

	Expectation	Reality
Previous event	Participant finds the previous event	Participant discovered the event as expected
Guest List	Participant finds the person from guest list	Participant discovered the guest list as expected
Text attendee	Participant sends a text to the person	Participant performed the tasks as expected